



BEIJING: PM Shehbaz Sharif, Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir, and Deputy PM Ishaq Dar pose for a photo with Chinese President Xi Jinping.—APP

Xi pledges economic support for Pakistan

• PM expresses gratitude for ‘unflinching support to Pakistan’s territorial integrity, sovereignty’; Beijing raises issue of its nationals’ security • Pakistan, Russia keen to boost trade; Putin invites Shehbaz to visit

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: Chinese President Xi Jinping in a meeting with Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Tuesday pledged support for Pakistan’s home-grown capacity for development, expressing readiness to build China-Pakistan Economic Corridor 2.0 and upgrade the China-Pakistan Free Trade Agreement, and step up cooperation in industries, agriculture, and mining sectors.

Separately, Russian President Vladimir Putin noted that bilateral trade between Pakistan and Russia required to be enhanced and stressed on taking steps in this regard, while also extending invitation to PM Shehbaz to visit Russia in November.

The PM, who held separate meetings with President Xi and President Putin in Beijing during his visit to China to attend SCO summit, expressed gratitude to both countries

for what he called ‘unflinching support to Pakistan’s territorial integrity, sovereignty’ and hope that the strong ties would add to the progress and prosperity of the region.

According to PM Office, Pakistan and China on Tuesday reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening the iron-clad and all-weather strategic cooperative partnership through enhanced cooperation, reflecting their unique bilateral relationship.

The bilateral ties and cooperation were discussed in a meeting between PM Shehbaz and Chinese President Xi at the Great Hall of the People, wherein they agreed that the relationship between both countries was unique and unparalleled, which should be reflected in their enhanced cooperation. PM Shehbaz appreciated “China’s unflinching support to Pakistan’s territorial integrity, sovereignty, and socio-economic development, as well

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Kalabagh propaganda finds no takers, save for Punjab

By Ikram Junaidi

ISLAMABAD: After igniting a storm over his 'conditional' support for the controversial Kalabagh Dam, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Ali Amin Gandapur on Tuesday doubled down on his statement, saying it was the need of the hour.

The KP CM's support for the long-proposed-but-never-built project stirred a veritable hornet's nest, with even his own party leaders opposing his endorsement for the controversial project.

However, the maverick politician's views prompted endorsement from unlikely quarters — the Punjab government, led by PML-N.

A day earlier, at rain-hit event held at KP House in Islamabad, the KP CM had expressed 'conditional support' for projects like the Kalabagh Dam, saying they were necessary for the sake of future generations.

However, in the same breath, he said that the reservations of all stakeholders, including provinces, should be

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13 lives lost, 35 hurt in suicide bombing after BNP rally

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• Akhtar Mengal, Mehmood Achakzai, ANP and National Party leaders, who were also present at the gathering, remained unhurt • Five security men martyred in Kech IED blast

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: At least 13 people were killed and 35 others injured in a suicide bombing near Shahwani Stadium in the Sariab area here on Tuesday night, shortly after the conclusion of a public meeting of the Balochistan National Party (BNP-Mengal) held to mark the death anniversary of the late Sardar Attaullah Mengal.

BNP President and MNA Sardar Akhtar Mengal, who presided over the gathering, remained unhurt as

the blast occurred when he was leaving for home. Pakhtunkhwa Milli Awami Party (PkMAP) chief Mehmood Khan Achakzai, Asghar Khan Achakzai of the Awami

Six men martyred as forces repel attack on Bannu FC HQ:
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National Party (ANP), and former senator Mir Kabeer Muhammad Shai

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Dykes breached as Chenab, Ravi rivers hit critical levels

• Ravi at Sidhnai in exceptionally high flood at 1am with 173,000 cusecs flow
• Explosives used at Mai Safura dyke to protect irrigation structures • Multan faces flood threat; 100 villages at risk near Muhammad Wala • Chenab floods devastate homes, crops in Jhang; locals allege favouritism • PM reviews flood response from Beijing • PMD forecasts more rains

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: The authorities started breaching dykes as the raging Chenab and Ravi rivers threaten to unleash an unprecedented deluge towards the densely populated cities of south Punjab as the water levels reach critical gauges near the headworks of Sidhnai and Muhammad Wala.

In a statement released after midnight on Wednesday, the Punjab Provincial Disaster Management Authority (PDMA) said the Ravi River at Head Sidhnai had entered an extremely high flood stage.

To avert a major disaster, controlled breaches were carried out at the Mai Safura dyke near Head Sidhnai. PDMA officials confirmed

that two cuts were made using explosives to release pressure on the embankment.

PDMA Director General Irfan Ali Kathia said the breaches were executed under emergency circumstances to protect vital irrigation structures. He stressed that the decision was unavoidable, as rising floodwaters posed a severe threat to the safety of the embankment and surrounding infrastructure.

The breaches came as the Punjab government took emergency measures, including placing explosives at three strategic locations to conduct controlled breaches and prevent catastrophic urban flooding.

The convergence of the Ravi with the Chenab at Ahmadpur Sial is expected to significantly raise water levels in the Chenab, amplify-

ing flood threats for the districts of Khanewal, Multan and Muzaffargarh. Authorities installed dynamite upstream of Sidhnai Headworks, at Head Muhammad Wala, and near Sher Shah to protect critical infrastructure.

The Sidhnai breach will affect Pirmahal, Khanewal, Kot Diwan, Kund Sargana, Kund Malkani, Kabiwala Maqsoodpur and Behrampur.

The breach before Head Muhammad Wala will submerge more than 100 villages and mouzas of the district Multan, including

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Four killed in rain-related incidents across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa: Page 8

Villagers marooned after deadly floods in Indian Punjab: Page 12



Muhammad Pur Ghotla, Sorij Miani, Qasim Bela, Muzaffarabad and mouza Wolwat.

While the breach at Sher Shah will submerge mouza Jungle Wala, Gadar Kachumer, mouza Buch, Sehri Wala, Sultanpur Hamar, mouza Jamoor, Khanpur Qazi and others.

High flood in River Tawi

Earlier, the PDMA chief said that high flooding might occur in the Tawi River. Speaking at a press conference in Lahore, Mr Kathia said: "An alert was issued by the Indian

FLOOD-HIT people take shelter at a makeshift relief camp on the outskirts of Multan.—AFP

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Khawaja Asif's outburst comes under 'friendly fire' in NA

• Hanif Abbasi suggests defence minister resign instead of 'abusing bureaucracy for publicity' • PTI boycotts NA proceedings, holds parallel 'public assembly' outside Parliament House

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: Differences within the federal cabinet surfaced on Tuesday during a National Assembly debate on the flood crisis when Railways Minister Hanif Abbasi openly criticised Defence Minister Khawaja Mohammad Asif for his remarks on the government's handling of the disaster.

Although he did not name his cabinet colleague, Mr Abbasi made multiple references to the defence

minister's speech on the floor of the house a day earlier.

He even suggested that Mr Asif resign from the cabinet instead of "levelling allegations against parliament and abusing bureaucracy only to gain [media] publicity".

Meanwhile, members of the opposition PTI boycotted the proceedings and staged a parallel "public assembly" outside Parliament House to protest alleged political victimisation.

Speaking in the debate, Mr Abbasi accused some politicians of

attacking institutions simply to go viral on social media. "If this is all they have to say, they should leave the government benches and sit in the opposition, because such language does not suit treasury members," said Mr Abbasi, who was elected MNA from Rawalpindi.

On Monday, Khawaja Asif had described the recent devastation as a "man-made disaster", blaming politicians and bureaucrats for unchecked encroachments on

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Settlements near Bahawalpur face land erosion threat by Sutlej

By Majeed Gill

BAHAWALPUR: Basti Mari Qasim Shah in the suburbs of Bahawalpur city is threatened by erosion as about four acres of the land on its outskirts has already been submerged by the river Sutlej floodwaters.

According to the residents, after erosion of its four acres, now the floodwaters were just around eight acres away from the basti. Apprehending submergence of the settlement by the fast-approaching floodwaters, they urged the authorities to take measures to check the land erosion within a day or two.

Similarly, Fatowali village, located between Bahawalpur and Sammasatta railway station, is also threatened by the Sutlej erosion and the locals have appealed the authorities to send heavy machinery to dump sandbags and stones to save the area.

On Tuesday, a private dyke near Basti Bhinda, in the suburb of Bahawalpur city, developed a breach, resulting in inundation of the agricultural land around the settlement. However, the residents of the settlement have already been evacuated to safer places.

The flood-affected people in the Basti Shera flood relief camp say they badly need dry fodder (wanda) for their livestock.

In Multan district, according to the administration, the number of flood relief camps has been increased to 90 with the increasing number of the flood-hit people in the area.

The administration claimed to have arranged meals and other basic facilities for the people in the taking shelter in the camps. Officials say that dry fodder has also been supplied for the cattle heads in the camps.

Meanwhile, Senate Chairman Syed Yusuf Raza Gilani on Tuesday visited the flood-affected areas outside Multan city.

Mr Gilani visited the flood relief camps at the Shershah Girls High School and Buch Phatak, besides the Shershah Toll Plaza dyke.

Talking to the media, Gilani claimed that there were adequate stocks of anti-diarrhea and skin ailments medicines, in addition to the antivenom for snake-bite cases.

Ejaz moves LHC ~~Page 2~~ disqualification

LAHORE: PTI's incarcerated ex-senator Ejaz Chaudhry has filed a fresh petition in the Lahore High Court challenging his disqualification following conviction in May 9 cases.

In his plea, Mr Ejaz contends that an anti-terrorism court sentenced him in the May 9 cases, following which the Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP) issued a notification disqualifying him from his Senate membership.

The petitioner argues that disqualification from the Senate cannot be carried out without granting the right to appeal against the conviction.

He pleaded that the ECP, contrary to this principle, issued the impugned notification on the Senate chairman's reference, which was 'unlawful'.

The petitioner further objected to the commission's issuance of the schedule for the Senate by-election, terming it illegal. The petitioner, therefore, asked the court to declare both the disqualification notification and the by-election schedule unconstitutional and void. — Staff Reporter

Probe holds Gogi, Teefi 'guilty' of Balaj's murder

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By Asif Chaudhry

LAHORE: A team of investigation officers has reportedly found that the two "underworld dons" – Khwaja Tareef alias Teefi Butt and Khwaja Aqeel alias Gogi Butt – are allegedly involved in the murder of Ameer Balaj Tipu, son of late Tipu Truckanwala.

Sources say the investigators' team, working under the supervision of Sadar division investigation SP, has sent a final report on the high-profile murder case to the police high-ups.

They say that according to the report, Teefi Butt has been instrumental in orchestrating Balaj's murder, in connivance with Gogi Butt and other suspects, including the shooters, who targeted the victim. The both sides are said to have a 35-year old family feud.

Sharing details of the findings, a senior officer says that the family of the slain Balaj had no enmity with anyone in the city, except Teefi and Gogi.

During the decades old feud, the report says, several armed attacks were carried out against the elders

of Balaj, including his father Tipu Truckanwala and grandfather Billa Truckanwala, who were finally murdered. The family suffered heavy losses of lives and property because of the feud.

The official says that following all these attacks, Gogi and Teefi were nominated and challaned in the cases registered against them, but Balaj's family had never nominated the other family members of the both suspects in any case.

About the modus operandi of the suspected killers of Balaj, the official says quoting the report that the car (BRV, 2017 model) that was used in the crime was rented from its owner Ameen.

He says the suspected shooters, including Muzafar Shah, Haroon and Bilawal, allegedly reached the house of Teefi Butt in Gulberg to finalise the "murder plan". They were allegedly provided weapons by Teefi and dispatched to the venue in Chuhng area, where Balaj was attending a wedding, the official adds.

Quoting the findings of the investigation, the police officer says, the suspects reached the Canal View Housing Society near Thokar where

Gogi Butt resided, adding that they then went to the Park View Society through Multan Road, where the wedding was being held.

The official says that the wedding function had almost ended and Ameer Balaj was about to leave along with his fellows, when the suspects suddenly opened fire, leaving the target dead on the spot.

As per the report, the prime suspect, Gogi Butt, remained in hiding for one and a half years since the murder and did not join the investigation. He was declared a proclaimed offender while the alleged shooters were arrested and sent on judicial remand by the court. The report also contained the statements of all the witnesses and the circumstantial evidences which prove that the nominated suspects were "guilty" of the murder charges.

To a question, the official said that senior police officers would call a meeting to review the findings of the investigation and take a final decision in this regard soon.

Ameer Balaj Tipu was killed on Feb 19, 2024, during a wedding ceremony in Lahore's Chuhng area.

Crisis in the making

Complaints of missing facilities emerge from flood-hit areas

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: The humanitarian crisis is escalating in southern Punjab as exceptionally high flood levels in the Sutlej, Ravi, and Chenab rivers have inundated hundreds of villages, forcing thousands of families to flee their homes with minimal assistance from the state.

The Provincial Disaster Management Authority (PDMA) has predicted the flood situation in the rivers but affected communities complain that the response on ground is too little, too late that has left a trail of devastation in their fields.

The government had evacuated 529,938 people from Multan division, including 351,230 from district Multan, 102,645 from Khanewal, 56,763 from Vehari and 19,300 from Lodhran.

The District Muzaffargarh administration evacuated 68,043 people from its three tehsils, including Muzaffargarh, Alipur and Jatoti.

The government has established 25 flood relief camps in different areas of Multan, including Lakwala, Muhammadpur Mahota on Head Muhammadwala, Sher Shah, Bund Bosan and Sikandri Nala.

A flood relief camp has been established at Head Muhammadwala where over 250 families are residing.

The flood affected persons said they were living in the open for the last two days and did not receive any help from the government. They said they were forced to leave their houses without picking their belongings, which could be destroyed in water or get stolen.

Replying to a query about commis-

sioner and district administration's claims to have served the food and fodder for cattle, the people said they received rice two times in the last two days and no one provided them with fodder for their animals. They complained about the absence of clean water to drink, medical help and washroom facility, saying that children and women were facing problems due to non-availability of washrooms.

Flood affected people living at a BHU said there were two washrooms for more than 2,000 people and that they receiving only one-time meal while their children were contracting diseases due to contaminated water.

In tehsil Shujaabad and Jalalpur, people living in low-lying areas complained about the police and district administration for issuing them threats of dire consequences for not leaving their homes.

They said that there was no electricity in the flood relief centres and there were a lot of mosquitoes.

Sajjad from Shujaabad said that assistant commissioner office employees and police officials ordered him to leave the house but he refused.

"The officials asked me to leave the house or they would set it on fire. I had to leave my belongings and now I am living without a roof, food and washrooms under the sky." He said there were several families living in the camp and some were provided with cloth tents and it did not stop rain water.

Multan Commissioner Amir Kareem Khan visited flood-prone areas, including Basti Muhammadpur Ghoti, Jhok Venus, Sher Shah, Lukwala Bund, Hajipur and Basti Langrial, to review ongoing relief

operations. The number of flood relief camps across the division was increased to 90.

In Burewala, Sahoka and surrounding settlements were submerged after a breach in the Sahoka-Chishtian Road which resulted in disconnecting hundreds of villages from the city.

"Our village is now an island," explained Ayesha Bibi from Sahoka.

"The main road is under water. We are using makeshift boats to get to safety but where do we go? We have heard about relief camps but we have not seen any."

In Manchanabad, temporary protective embankments at Mauza Rateeka, Lala Amar Singh, and several other villages were washed away, submerging thousands of acres of agricultural land and rice, cotton and maize crops. The floodwaters also cut off road access to multiple settlements.

In the Arifwala area, Basti Saboka, Yasin Kay, Balara Dilawar, and Balara Arjan were submerged. Several villages have lost road connectivity due to broken roads.

In Vehari, rescue teams relocated people and their livestock from the affected villages, including Lakhha Saldira, Sahooka, Farooqabad, Jamlera.

More than 80 villages were submerged and rural link roads eroded after high flood in the Ravi River at Kamalia. Officials said over 60,000 people were evacuated and 890 of them were given first aid.

Their 61,999 animals were also evacuated. The road leading to Chichawatni, Faisalabad and M-3 interchange was submerged with floodwater near Kalaira Adda at Kamalia.

DC's order barring food distribution among flood-hit challenged

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: A petition filed in the Lahore High Court challenges a notification issued by the Gujrat deputy commissioner (DC), barring the distribution of food among the flood-hit people without clearance from the Punjab Food Authority (PFA).

The petitioner, Nasir Hussain, states that the DC issued the impugned notification on Aug 29, 2025, prohibiting any non-governmental organisation or individual from providing food to the flood-hit people. He argued that the notification is a violation of the Constitution.

He further states that while many areas are currently hit by the floods, no such notification has been issued anywhere else in the country.

He maintains that preventing any person from helping the flood-hit people is a violation of both "humanity and the law." Therefore, he asks the court to set aside the DC's notification.

The impugned notification cites some reports about the distribution of unchecked food in the flood-affected areas of Gujrat district, posing a serious threat to public health.

"No food, cooked or uncooked, food hampers, edibles, drinking water, milk and any eatable item shall be distributed without a written clearance from the Punjab Food Authority/District Health Authority, Gujrat, in the territorial jurisdiction of the district," the notification says.

Water level at Trimmu Headworks decreasing

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People criticise breach made on the west side of Sultan Bahu Bridge

By Tariq Saeed

TOBA TEK SINGH: The Chenab floodwater has vastly damaged crops and houses in hundreds of rural localities in Jhang district.

Although the high level of water crossed 550,000 cusecs on Monday, its level is going down at Trimmu Headworks and when this report was filed on Tuesday evening, its flow was 399,000 cusecs.

In Daduana Kuhna, a locality 20km from Jhang near the main spur on Chund Bharwana side, rice and sugarcane crops had been completely destroyed by floodwater. The mud houses of peasants were demolished while the cemented houses had also developed cracks.

In reply to a question about relief camps or help of government in floodwater area, a flood affected person said no relief reached him; however, philanthropists of nearby areas provided meals for them and fodder for their livestock.

Khan Nawazish Ali Sial, a landlord and brother of a former MPA Auon Ali Sial, said hundreds of acres of crops had been inundated by floodwater which reached his area in Garh Maharaja due to the wrong decision of the administration under which a breach was made on the west side of Sultan Bahu Bridge on Chenab.

"The breach caused havoc in the area and houses in localities and crops had badly been damaged. The breach should have been created on the east side of bridge on the Shorkot city side where there was no population but only crops fields. But to save crops of some influential land owners in Shorkot tehsil, the breach was not made on the eastern side of the bridge."

Sial said water speed was yet high

and it was moving towards 2,000 years old historical locality of Pir Abdul Rehman. He added that Chenab water was going towards those localities of Ahmadpur Sial where it could meet the Ravi floodwater.

According to latest situation, water has suspended traffic from Sultan Bahu bridge to Garh Maharaja and motorists from Layyah and Bhakkar on the way to M-4 interchange near Shorkot were forced to adopt alternate routes.

The Jhang administration spokesperson Riaz Marth claimed that relief camps were functional after every 500 meters in the flood-affected areas.

He said the decision about the breach on the road on one side of Sultan Bahu Bridge was decided after consultation with locals. He refuted the propaganda that crops of any of the influential were saved and added that unexpected high flow of water had caused destruction in the Garh Maharaja area.

Mr Marth said every single person or animal trapped in floodwater was traced and through the Safe City Authority's thermal drones and rescued and added that the Jhang Safe City Authority had pointed out 36 areas, locating 160 trapped individuals in severe flood conditions and guiding rescue and police teams.

The people demanded the CM to accept their genuine demand to declare the Jhang district's affected areas as calamity-hit to waive agriculture taxes, water rate and other levies.

Jhang Traffic Police Officer Saeed Akhtar Dholka said the traffic had been suspended from Shorkot Tehsil Chowk to Kabirwala, (Khanewal) via Pul Bhaghar as river Ravi floodwater is flowing over the Jhang -Kabirwala Road near Kot Islam.

In Toba Tek Singh district, traffic towards Kabirwala and Multan had also been suspended from Pirmahal -Faisalabad Road at Head Sidhnai on Ravi due to very high level of floodwater.

Neelum-Jhelum project ‘a failure of planning, execution’

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• AGP report finds Rs507bn scheme plagued by tunnel collapses, delays and cost overruns • Flagship project falls short on water rights, power output

By Khaleeq Kiani

ISLAMABAD: The Auditor General of Pakistan (AGP) has declared the Rs507 billion Neelum-Jhelum Hydropower Project a failure in terms of objectives, planning and execution, saying it neither secured Pakistan’s water rights nor delivered the designed energy output, as its multiple tunnel faults and collapses have raised serious questions about the quality of work on a project of national importance.

In its performance audit report for 2022-23, submitted to the president and parliament, the AGP noted that the findings did not even include the major collapse of the headrace tunnel last year, which has kept the project shut. The report was finalised based on responses from Wapda’s management to audit objections.

According to the report, the project faced considerable delays despite the pro-

vision of tunnel boring machines (TBMs) meant to speed up excavation, mainly due to design changes.

“The project could not reap envisaged benefits of generation of planned electricity, establishment of water rights over Neelum River, selling of carbon credits under CDM, and completion of mitigation measures to safeguard the environment,” the AGP said.

Although the first unit was commissioned in 2018, contractors failed to complete pending punch list items, fulfil contractual obligations, or supply spare parts needed for smooth operation. “The major collapse in the tailrace tunnel (TRT) of the powerhouse just a few years after construction also casts doubt on the quality of design and works,” it added.

The report recalled that Wapda was to execute the project in line with the original PC-I, approved by the Executive Committee of the National Economic

Council (Ecneec) in December 1989 at a cost of Rs15.012bn. After three intermediate revisions, Ecneec approved the fourth revised PC-I in May 2018 at Rs506.808bn, against which Rs423.446bn had been spent up to June 2023.

The project was delayed by almost eight years, raising its cost from Rs84.502bn (first revised PC-I) to Rs419.454bn, a cost overrun of Rs334.952bn. The AGP said the project was not executed efficiently as resources were poorly managed and timelines under PC-I were ignored. Contractual issues also remained unresolved due to contractors’ delays.

On its effectiveness, the audit concluded the project failed to deliver its objectives of cheap electricity and securing water rights over the Neelum River. The TRT collapse forced the powerhouse to remain shut until March 2023, leading to massive generation losses and worsening load shedding. “Neither the envisaged benefits of generat-

ing 5,150GWh annually were achieved nor water rights over the Neelum River established, particularly after Pakistan lost the Kishenganga case in the International Court of Arbitration,” the report noted.

The four generating units came online between July and December 2018. Funding was arranged through cash development loans from the federal government, Wapda’s own equity, the Neelum-Jhelum surcharge on electricity consumers, and local and foreign loans. The audit was conducted under INTOSAI Auditing Standards, Performance Audit Manual, and relevant rules.

Key audit findings included failure to generate the planned 5,150GWh annually, failure to establish water rights on the Neelum/Kishenganga, a nine-year time overrun, and a cost overrun of Rs338.944bn. Other serious lapses cited were an increase in the project’s payback period from five to 12 years, non-realisation of \$50.133m in revenue under the Clean Development Mecha-

nism, reduced annual generation, and environmental damage due to poor studies at the planning stage worth Rs3.05bn.

The report also highlighted Rs70.44bn in lost revenue due to non-approval of reference tariff by Nepra, Rs20.387bn in generation losses from the TRT collapse without inquiry, unjustified excess payment of Rs1.78bn to contractors without verifying raw stone aggregate quantities, non-recovery of costs for unexecuted telecom works and advance payments for an 11kV overhead line, undue benefits to contractors due to non-reinstatement of spoil deposits, non-indemnification of a Rs42bn insurance claim for the TRT collapse, and non-supply of spare parts and failure to execute punch list items by contractors.

The AGP concluded that the Neelum-Jhelum project fell short on nearly every planned objective, leaving behind massive financial losses, unresolved contractual disputes, and serious structural flaws.

La Nina may return to impact climate patterns from Sept onward: WMO

By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: La Nina may return to impact weather and climate patterns from September onward, according to the latest World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) update. But despite the temporary cooling influence of La Nina, temperatures are still expected to be above average for much of the world, the WMO cautioned on Tuesday.

The WMO data indicates a 55 per cent likelihood that sea surface temperatures in the equatorial Pacific will cool to La Nina levels from September to November. About 90 per cent of the excess heat from global warming is stored in the ocean, making ocean heat content a critical indicator of climate change.

“For October to December 2025, the probability of La Nina conditions slightly increases to about 60 per cent. There is little chance of El Nino developing during September to December,” WMO said in an update.

According to the UN agency, there is a slim chance (45 per cent) that Pacific temperatures will stay as they have for the past six months, when neither the cooling La Niña nor its opposite number, the warming El Niño, caused unusual spikes or dips in sea surface temperatures.

The UN agency’s forecast for the El Niño Southern Oscillation phenomenon is an important climate intelligence tool which could “save thousands of lives when used to guide preparedness and response actions”, insisted WMO Secretary-General, Celeste Saulo.

The information could also translate into millions of dollars of savings in agriculture, energy, health and transport, she said.

Important as La Nina and El Nino are in shaping our climate by altering ocean surface temperatures and impacting changes in winds, pressure and rainfall patterns, human-induced climate change is still “increasing global temperatures, exacerbating extreme weather, and impacting seasonal rainfall and temperature patterns”, the WMO noted

Each year of the past decade has been the top 10 warmest on record, the UN agency warned earlier this year, with 2024 the hottest yet, with “exceptional land and sea surface temperatures and ocean heat”.

Citing six international datasets, WMO said that global average surface temperature was 1.55 °C (34.79F) above the 1850-1900 average.

Six men martyred as forces repel attack on Bannu FC HQ

• ISPR says terrorists drove explosives-laden vehicle into the perimeter wall; all five attackers killed after 12-hour operation • Two cops targeted in Lakki Marwat; one terrorist killed in subsequent police action

By Ghulam Mursalin Marwat

LAKKI MARWAT: At least eight law enforcement and security personnel were martyred in separate terrorist attacks in Bannu and Lakki Marwat districts on Tuesday, which included an on the Bannu headquarters of the Federal Constabulary (FC).

According to ISPR, five terrorists from the Fitna-al-Khawarij — the term used by the state for the banned Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan — attacked the FC HQ and rammed an explosive-laden vehicle into the perimeter wall.

The suicide blast resulted in the partial collapse of the perimeter wall and damage to adjacent civilian infrastructure inflicting injuries to three innocent civilians, the ISPR statement said.

It said that six brave soldiers, belonging to Federal Constabulary and Pakistan Army, were martyred in the line of duty.

According to Bannu Regional Police Officer Sajjad Khan, the attack began in the early hours of Tuesday, when five terrorists entered the compound.

He said the teams of police and security forces rushed to the spot within minutes after the attack and launched a full-scale operation against terrorists at 5:15am, while roads leading to the FC lines were closed during the operation, which continued until the evening.

“The law enforcers confined the terrorists to a place where they could not do much damage,” the RPO said, adding that all terrorists were eliminated and sanitisation operation ensued.

The FC compound was finally cleared at 5:30pm, after a 12-hour-long operation,



BANNU: Paramilitary soldiers survey the damage caused after terrorists attacked the Federal Constabulary headquarters.—Reuters

he said. Four policemen, six army men and seven FC soldiers sustained injuries during the exchange of fire, he said, adding that they were taken to hospital.

“An injured SHO of the cantonment police station was airlifted to Peshawar after being operated upon at a local hospital,” the RPO said.

Two cops martyred

Separately, terrorists opened fire on two police officials, who were on their way to their place of duty on a motorbike in Lakki Marwat.

As a result, police constables Asad Khan and Samiullah were martyred on Begukhel Road, an official said.

“After the attack, a heavy contingent led by DPO Nazir Khan and SP Murad

Khan launched a search in the area to track down terrorists,” the official said.

Backed by commandos from the counter-terrorism department (CTD), Al Burq and Elite Force and armoured personnel carriers, police also launched an offensive against terrorists in the Michenkhel, Wanda Amir, Nawerkhel and other adjacent localities simultaneously, the official said.

“The law enforcers were equipped with advanced weapons and drone technology to hunt out and neutralise militants,” he said.

During the operation in the Nawerkhel area, police came under attack and in the ensuing exchange of fire, a terrorist was killed, while a policeman sustained wounds, the official said.

Two IHC judges call for agenda revision ahead of today's full court

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Letter highlights concerns over deteriorating state of court administration; criticises lack of effective oversight on lower courts

By Malik Asad

ISLAMABAD: Two judges — Justice Babar Sattar and Justice Sardar Ejaz Ishaq Khan — wrote letters to Chief Justice Sardar Mohammad Sarfraz Dogar before his maiden full court meeting after taking over as the regular chief justice of the Islamabad High Court (IHC).

As the new judicial year commenced in the IHC on Tuesday, Justice Dogar has called a full court session for 2pm today (Wednesday) and directed all judges of the IHC to ensure their attendance.

Although the detailed agenda has not been made public, such meetings are generally convened at the start of the judicial year to review court's performance, discuss administrative affairs, and set priorities for the coming months.

However, the letters written by two judges a day before the full court meeting stunned their colleagues as well as IHC officials, as sources privy to the development said that the judges sought to revise the agenda of the full court.

In his letter, Justice Babar Sattar raised grave concerns regarding the deteriorating state of the court's administration, alleging systemic violations of constitutional norms, judicial independence, and institutional integrity.

The letter criticised the lack of effective oversight over lower courts, which, he argued, has led to instability and inefficiency within the district judiciary. Justice Sattar alleged that case assignments and bench formations are being manipulated to sideline senior judges, including the Senior Puisne Judge, in favour of recently transferred or additional judges.

The letter cited instances of administrative overreach, including unauthorised case transfers, refusal to issue cause lists per judicial orders, and abrupt changes to judges' dockets aimed at rendering them "dysfunctional." Justice Sattar accused the Chief Justice of violating IHC rules and institutional norms by excluding senior judges from key administrative committees, thereby undermining the court's collegial character.

The letter condemned new circulars requiring judges to seek permission from the Chief Justice for international travel, as well as proposed rules that would centralise administrative powers—a move described as transforming the office into a "monocracy."

The letter concluded with a plea for introspection and corrective action, emphasising that without honest acknowledgment of failings, the institution cannot be repaired.

Governor praises Japan's role in Balochistan's uplift

Page 3

QUETTA: Balochistan Governor Jaffar Khan Mandokhail has said that Japan has played an important role in the development of Balochistan.

Mr Mandokhail said this during a meeting with Honorary Consul General of Japan, Syed Nadeem Shah, and Director of Japan Consulate,

Quetta, Israr Ahmed Adeel, who met the governor at the Governor House on Tuesday.

The governor said Japan has provided special assistance to the people of Balochistan at the time of natural disasters and it also provided aid in infrastructure development of the province.

Notable cooperation and

help in this regard include construction of a steel bridge at DG Khan-Rakni Barkhan Road, Fort Munroe, and construction of Wadh to Kararo Road, he said.

Mr Mandokhail said that as the higher education sector of Balochistan is developing, Japan's experience and technology in this sector can pro-

vide better support and guidance.

Scholarships for university students and especially collaboration and guidance between Japanese industries and public sector universities of Balochistan will have a positive impact on the economy and education of the province.—Saleem Shahid

Dykes breached as Chenab and Ravi hit critical levels

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High Commission and a high flood may occur in the River Tawi.”

The Chenab River's flow has increased by 60,000 cusecs in one hour, he added. Heavy rains were lashing India-held Jammu's Tawi, and heavy showers were also happening in northern Punjab, he said, adding that the water flow would increase.

Water flow

According to the Flood Forecasting Division's data released at 1am on Wednesday, the Chenab River at Marala Headworks was in high flood and flowing at 237,678 cusecs, with a rising trend.

Head Khanki was in medium flood and was flowing at 166,529 cusecs (rising trend), while Qadirabad was in low flood and was flowing at 128,078 cusecs (steady). Head Trimmu was also in high flood at 385,911 cusecs, but the flow was falling.

On the Ravi River, Head Sidhnai was in exceptionally high flood with a flow of 173,734 cusecs and rising. Upstream, Balloki was in high flood at 125,930 (steady), Shahdara in low flood at 49,280 (steady), and Jassar also in low flood at 63,720 (rising).

On the Sutlej River, Head Ganda Singh Wala was in exceptionally high flood at 269,501 cusecs (steady), Head Sulemanki was in high flood at 124,913 cusecs (steady) while Head Islam was in medium flood at 95,727 cusecs (steady).

At Panjnad, where five rivers — the Sutlej, Beas, Ravi, Jhelum, and Chenab — converge, the water flow was 169,207 cusecs (steady) and fell into the category



MULTAN: Heavy machinery is being deployed to raise protective dykes, with soil and sandbags, near Head Muhammad Wala.—APP

of low flood.

Multan under threat

Multan Commissioner Amir Kareem Khan said the city is still under the threat of flood, and explosives were installed to breach the Head Muhammad Wala protective dyke if it attained the maximum gauge level of 417.

He said that a committee of experts would decide whether to conduct a controlled breach in any dyke after reviewing three major factors: whether the water level is reaching a critical gauge, whether the water is creating a threat to infrastructure (such as the Head Muhammad Wala Bridge), and whether the

rising water will damage the protective dyke.

Mr Khan said that the water flow from Trimmu Barrage was slow and the water level reached the critical gauge at Jhok Vaince, from where the Multan district starts.

The rescue operation in the district was complete, and the water level did not reach the critical gauge at Head Muhammad Wala yet and was flowing at 409 feet from sea level, he added.

Meanwhile, Punjab Information Minister Azma Bokhari said that around one million people and over 700,000 livestock had been relocated to safer areas. In total, 3,243 villages and a population of more than 2.4m

had been affected by the floods,” she said.

“The government has set up 395 relief camps, providing shelter and food to affected families, along with 392 medical camps and 336 veterinary camps to ensure the protection of both human and animal lives.”

Homes, crops damaged in Jhang

Floodwaters from the Chenab have devastated crops and homes across Jhang district, particularly in Chund Bharwana, Daduana Kuhna and Ahmadpur Sial, where rice and sugarcane fields and mud houses were destroyed.

While a breach near Rivaz Bridge helped divert water and protect some areas, locals said no government relief reached them, with aid instead coming from nearby philanthropists.

In Ahmadpur Sial, residents accused the authorities of creating a breach on the wrong side of the Sultan Bahoo Bridge to protect influential landowners' crops, which they said worsened the destruction in Garh Maharaja.

However, district officials rejected allegations of favouritism, insisting the breach decision was made after consultation.

More rains forecast

The Pakistan Meteorological Department predicted scattered thunderstorms and isolated showers over the next 24 hours in river catchments and divisions, including Islamabad, Rawalpindi, Sargodha, Gujranwala, Lahore, Sahiwal, Multan, Dera Ghazi Khan and Bahawalpur.

The Pakistan Commission of Indus Waters reported a high flood in the Tawi

River, warning that it would impact downstream districts via the Chenab, including Gujrat, Gujranwala, Sialkot and Narowal.

The Flood Forecasting Division has also cautioned that the Chenab at Marala, Khanki and Qadirabad is likely to reach high flood levels within 24 hours, with associated tributaries and nullahs expected to swell across multiple divisions and districts.

PM reviews flood response

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif chaired a high-level review meeting on the country's flood situation and rescue and relief efforts from Beijing, where he is on an official visit.

The premier briefly set aside his engagements to receive a detailed briefing from the chairman of the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), chief secretaries of Punjab, Sindh and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, and other relevant departments.

The NDMA reported close coordination with provincial governments and disaster management authorities to monitor river flows at Trimmu, Balloki, Sidhnai, Ganda Singh Wala and Sulemanki, while flood peaks were expected at Panjnad before moving downstream to Guddu Barrage in Sindh by Sept 6.

PM Shehbaz directed the National Highway Authority and the Ministry of Energy to prioritise restoration of damaged communication routes and electricity transmission systems. He stressed that federal and provincial governments must work in full coordination to ensure the timely evacuation of families, distribution of relief goods, and rehabilitation of affected infrastructure.

Over 21,600 Pakistanis imprisoned abroad, Senate body informed

Community welfare attachés begin visiting prisons to meet Pakistani detainees, say officials

By Bakhtawar Mian

ISLAMABAD: As many as 21,647 Pakistanis are imprisoned in different countries with majority of them in the Gulf States for their alleged involvement in various crimes and illegalities; officials of the interior and foreign affairs ministries informed a Senate committee on Tuesday.

More than 13,000 of the prisoners are under trial and over 8,000 of them convicted. The meeting was told that most of the people convicted were involved in smuggling and that 65 per cent cases were drug related. The Senate Standing Committee on Overseas Pakistanis and Human Resource Development held its meet-

ing in Parliament House with Senator Zeeshan Khanzada in the chair.

Senator Khanzada noted the urgency of the situation and stressed institutional coordination. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs informed the committee that after its instructions it was decided to form an inter-ministerial committee on prisoners, which will include ambassadors and officials from relevant ministries. Letters have already been sent to all Pakistani embassies and missions worldwide.

According to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the initiative will proceed in phases: First, meetings will be arranged with Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries and then engagement with Malaysia, Indonesia and Australia and lastly consultations with be held with the United Kingdom and European Union countries.

The committee was informed that community welfare attachés have begun visiting prisons abroad to meet Pakistani detainees.

However, Senator Nasir Butt rejected such claims and said, "No one

visits Pakistanis imprisoned in jails." Officials clarified that such visits have only recently started.

Chairman Khanzada directed the Ministry of Overseas Pakistanis to present a full report on the funds allocated for legal and welfare support to imprisoned Pakistanis in the next meeting.

This is the first initiative for details of funds and expenditure and it must be provided, he emphasised.

On migration issues, officials said there were 294 legal avenues for Pakistanis to travel to European Union countries, with student visas given priority. They noted that nearly 50 per cent of Pakistanis going to Italy travel legally while 50 per cent resort to illegal routes.

The committee expressed grave concern over reports that many citizens pay as much as Rs7 million to leave Pakistan illegally.

The committee dismissed recent claims about 40,000 Pakistani pilgrims disappearing in Iraq, declaring the matter a myth.

Senator Raja Nasir Abbas informed the committee that he personally raised the issue with the Iraqi leadership.

"I met the Prime Minister of Iraq, and he called it wrong. I also spoke to the Minister of Religious Affairs of Pakistan, who confirmed it was a mistake," Senator Abbas clarified.

Officials from the Ministry of Interior briefed the committee that only 27 Pakistanis were caught in Iraq, while a total of 30 out of 81 Pakistanis remain under trial.

Senator Raja Nasir Abbas criticised the treatment of Pakistani citizens abroad. The passports of Pakistanis are kept at airports in various countries including Iraq. This is a great insult to Pakistani citizens, and the government must take notice. Ministry officials assured him the matter would be taken up at the highest level.

Officials from the Ministry of Interior briefed the committee that only 27 Pakistanis were caught in Iraq, while 30 out of 81 Pakistanis remained under trial.

Plea against auction of mall disposed of as FBR withdraws order

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By Malik Asad

ISLAMABAD: The Islamabad High Court (IHC) on Tuesday disposed of a petition against the planned auction of the Mall of Islamabad, a project of Bahria Town, as the Federal Board of Revenue stepped back from its decision of auctioning the multi-storey building.

The FBR move came following objections from property owners who argued that their rights were being jeopardised by a “generic and unlawful” proclamation.

A division bench comprising Justice Khadim Hussain Soomro and Justice Mohammad Asif heard the case. During proceedings, FBR Deputy Commissioner Sohail Abbas informed the court that the order for the auction scheduled for September 3 had been withdrawn. He said the board would first confirm the allottees’ status before considering any auction process. The petition, filed by 14 shop owners in the Mall of Islamabad, challenged the FBR’s proclamation dated August 17.

The proclamation, issued to recover Rs26.4 billion in tax default from Bahria Town, declared the entire mall attached without specifying which properties belonged to the tax defaulter.

Through their counsel Muddasir Latif Abbasi, the petitioners argued that the vague proclamation violated Articles 4 and 24 of the Constitution, which guarantee protection of property rights and ignored Rule 129 of the Income Tax Rules 2002 that requires investigation into third-party ownership claims before an auction.

The counsel contended that his allotment certificate, possession certificate and payment record established his ownership beyond doubt, yet the FBR rejected his representation within a day without granting him a hearing.

An allottee told the bench: “Whether you recover Rs 26 billion or Rs126 billion, my property rights should not be affected. If overseas Pakistanis invest in the heart of Islamabad’s Blue Area and this is the fate they meet, why should anyone bring money into the country?”

Justice Soomro admonished the FBR for issuing identical “copy-paste” orders in multiple cases.

“We have seen your orders. Despite differences in cases, you did not even change commas or full stops. How will the state’s business run like this? Anarchy will spread if such practices continue,” he remarked, instructing the FBR to investigate thoroughly before taking coercive action. With the FBR formally withdrawing its proclamation, the court disposed of the matter.

Accused arrested for harassing TikToker given to police custody

Page 4

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: A man arrested in connection with the alleged harassment of a social media influencer and attempt to kidnap her was given in police custody on physical remand.

The police had arrested the man, a native of Lahore but a resident of Golra, the other day after the girl got a case registered against him on Sunday alleging that he had harassed, slapped and tried to kidnap her.

On Tuesday, Shalimar police produced the accused in the court of judicial magistrate to seek his remand. After hearing the arguments the magistrate gave him in police custody on physical remand.

Earlier, the accused gave a statement to the police about his relation with the girl and what happened on the day of the incident, a police officer said, adding that he told police that they had been acquaintances since long.

He claimed that when he came over to her house, she was making a video of him

with her mobile phone, which he snatched from her.

He said when she came to get back her mobile phone, he pushed her in the car and drove away. However, later he himself dropped her in front of the gate of her house.

The accused further told the police that he threw the mobile phone away and also pointed out the location where he had thrown it.

Earlier police registered a case against the accused in response to a complaint lodged by Samia Hijab, a resident of E-11 sector.

In her complaint, the victim sought immediate legal action against the accused who was personally acquainted to her. She went on to say that over time, his behaviour towards her turned into persistent harassment and intimidation and he started forcing her to go out with him against her will.

She further claimed that despite her clear discomfort and objections, he would come to her house repeatedly without her permission or consent and gave her gifts which she never accepted.

The complainant stated that

on August 31, around 6:30pm, when she went out of her house to return the gifts, he humiliated her in public and slapped her several times, thereby causing her great physical and mental trauma.

Prior to this incident, he had been stalking her since morning, persistently calling her, and issuing threats. On one of the phone calls, he categorically stated that if she stepped out, he would beat her.

In view of this, she was left with no option but to call 15 and report his whereabouts when he physically assaulted her.

Four Margalla trails closed after heavy rain forecast

Page 4

ISLAMABAD: The capital administration has closed four trails of the Margalla Hills till further orders keeping in view the forecast of torrential rainfall for the safety of the people.

Notification issued from the office of District Magistrate stated: "In view of recent heavy rainfall and keeping in view the safety of citizens, including hikers, visitors to the Margalla Hills, it is hereby notified that trail 2, 3, 4, 5 and trail behind Saidpur Village Shall remain closed till further orders for the public."

An official of the capital administration said the administration was in contact with the Met Office to get weather forecast and take necessary step to avoid any untoward incident.

On Wednesday, Islamabad and its surroundings will remain partly cloudy with a possibility of rain with gusty winds and tender storm. Besides, heavy rain is also expected at a few places with 60 percent probability.

The capital police were also asked to make necessary arrangements to ensure the order of the district magistrate is implemented in letter and spirit.

The police have also been deployed at the starting point of the trails at the foothills to stop people from hiking or visiting the hills. — Staff Reporter

PMYP, digital tourism platform sign LoI

Page 4

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: The Prime Minister's Youth Programme (PMYP) has signed a Letter of Intent (LoI) with Destinations, an innovative digital tourism platform, to engage young people in high-potential industries.

The signing ceremony, held at the Prime Minister's Office, was chaired by Rana Mashhood Ahmad Khan, Chairman of the Prime Minister's Youth Programme (PMYP).

This collaboration marks the beginning of a new era in leveraging technology while accel-

erating the digital transformation of Pakistan's tourism and creator economies.

Founded in 2015, Destinations is a leading media and digital innovation platform focused on sustainable tourism, youth entrepreneurship, and integrating Pakistan into the global halal economy. From its award-winning travel content to its AI-powered educational tools, Destinations is committed to advancing Pakistan's position on the world stage through digital innovation and storytelling.

The collaboration focuses on a shared vision of youth empowerment, job creation, eco-

nomic development, and enhancing Pakistan's global brand. By leveraging Destinations' cutting-edge AI platform, PMYP aims to unlock new opportunities for youth, helping them integrate into digital economies through training, technology, and entrepreneurship. This partnership will extend into education and entrepreneurship, creating further opportunities in fields such as sustainable tourism, the halal economy, and content creation.

This partnership is grounded in shared goals of youth empowerment, job creation, economic development, and enhancing Pakistan's tourism brand. It focuses on four key pillars.

Through this partnership, PMYP and Destinations are committed to ensuring local service providers, small businesses, tour guides, artisans, and youth across Pakistan gain access to the tools, training, and visibility needed

to thrive.

By integrating these stakeholders into a shared digital ecosystem, the partnership aims to foster entrepreneurship and sustainable economic participation in the digital tourism economy.

As part of this collaboration, PMYP and Destinations are focusing on two key areas to prepare youth for global opportunities.

The collaboration will offer students financial literacy and hands-on training to create sustainable, halal-compliant businesses. These could include eco-friendly guesthouses, sustainable cafés, and pop-up businesses, all designed to meet World Bank's sustainable tourism standards.

Asma Chishty, CEO of Destinations, commended the initiative. "Destinations turns discovery into love, and love into action — preparing Pakistan's youth to lead in climate resilience and halal innovation worldwide," she said.

5.4-magnitude quake follows tremors in Afghanistan

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Dawn Report

ISLAMABAD: The Pakistan Meteorological Department (PMD) on Tuesday said that tremors were felt in Peshawar, Mansehra and Islamabad after another earthquake struck eastern Afghanistan.

A PMD press release said the 5.4-magnitude earthquake occurred at 5:30pm in southeastern Afghanistan at a depth of 22 kilometres with tremors felt all the way in Peshawar, Mansehra, Islamabad, Abbottabad and Swat.

Meanwhile, the US Geological Survey reported it as a 5.2-magnitude earthquake 34 kilometres northeast of Jalalabad city in Nangarhar province.

The epicentre of the tremor was close to where a magnitude 6.0 earthquake hit late Sunday night, devastating remote areas in mountainous provinces near the border with Pakistan, reported *Dawn.com*.

The PMD earlier reported three more minor quakes in the day: a magnitude 4 in southeastern Afghanistan at 2:50pm at a depth of 97km, a magnitude 5.4 in China's Xinjiang at 12:59pm at a depth of 10km and a magnitude 4.4 in southeastern Afghanistan at 12:25pm at a depth of 20km.

Later in the day, the PMD reported another earthquake of magnitude 3 with the epicentre 24km northeast of Pattan at a depth of 46km at 7:10pm.

Govt announces public holiday on Saturday

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ISLAMABAD: The federal government on Tuesday announced a public holiday for Sept 6 on account of Eid Miladun Nabi (peace be upon him), Dawn.com reports. A notification in this regard was issued by the Cabinet Division.

Last week, the Central Ruet-i-Hilal Committee had announced that Eid Miladun Nabi will fall on coming Saturday. September 6 will also mark the country's 60th Defence Day, commemorating the sacrifices of the fallen heroes of the 1965 war against India.—Dawn Report

GB to auction hunting permits for 118 animals

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Only half of the permits offered in last season found buyers amid various challenges

By Jamil Nagri

GILGIT: The Gilgit-Baltistan (GB) Wildlife and Parks Department will auction permits for 118 animals—including four Astore markhors, 100 Himalayan ibex, and 14 blue sheep—for the 2025-26 hunting season.

The bidding ceremony is scheduled to be held today (Wednesday) at the Forest, Parks and Wildlife Complex in Gilgit.

For the upcoming season, the base price of an Astore markhor permit has been raised to \$200,000, while blue sheep and Himalayan ibex permits are set at \$30,000 and \$10,000, respectively. Last year, the base rates were lower: \$150,000 for markhor, \$9,000 for blue sheep, and \$5,500 for ibex. In the 2024-25 season, 118 permits were offered, but only 60 were purchased. The highest bid for a markhor reached \$161,000, earning the GB government more than Rs30 million.

Officials note that prices in other regions, such as Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, can reach \$500,000 for markhor hunts. However, local outfitters and tour operators argue the sharp fee hikes are damaging their businesses and discouraging international clients. They warn of losses for both outfitters and the local communities who rely on trophy hunting revenue.

Ikram Beg, a Gilgit-based outfitter, said participation in the programme has dropped due to inflated rates, causing “devastating” impacts on livelihoods.

Similarly, Syed Sumsam Ali Bokhari, chairman of Safari Club International Pakistan Chapter, warned that rising prices undermine Pakistan’s competitiveness compared to neighboring countries.

In Tajikistan, a markhor hunt costs about \$160,000 including logistics; in Nepal, blue sheep hunts average \$29,000; and ibex hunts in Central Asia range between \$8,500 and \$9,900.

Mr Bokhari added that security concerns, geopolitical tensions, and recent terrorist attacks in hunting regions such as Chitral further reduced country’s attractiveness as a destination.

He urged the GB wildlife department to reconsider its pricing strategy to align with regional market trends.

Launched in 1990 in Bar Valley, Nagar, GB’s trophy hunting programme involves local communities, who receive about 80 percent of hunting revenues for conservation and development projects.

While it has been credited with protecting endangered species, stakeholders fear the latest price hikes could jeopardise its sustainability.

Xi pledges support for Pakistan

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as the significance of the China Pakistan Economic Corridor as a flagship project of President Xi's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) to help both countries to build an even stronger Pakistan-China community with a shared future". He reaffirmed the desire to continue working closely with China for the successful implementation of the next phase of upgraded CPEC, with its five new corridors.

The PM Office quoted President Xi as saying that China would continue to assist Pakistan in all fields of economic growth and development, especially as the two countries were now ushering in second phase of CPEC that would focus on Pakistan's most important economic sectors.

PM Shehbaz renewed his "most cordial" invitation to President Xi to undertake an official visit to Pakistan next year when both countries would celebrate the 75th anniversary of establishment of Pakistan-China diplomatic ties.

Security issue

Also, President Xi said China supports Pakistan's efforts to combat terrorism and hopes "effective measures" would be taken to "ensure the safety and security of Chinese personnel, projects, and institutions in Pakistan, to create a secure environment for bilateral cooperation". According to Reuters, China pressed Pakistan to improve security of Chinese nationals, who have been repeatedly attacked by militants while working on Beijing-funded multi-billion-dollar infrastruc-



BEIJING: PM Shehbaz Sharif shakes hands with Russian President Vladimir Putin.—APP

ture projects in the South Asian country.

However, Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi, who joined the PM in China and attended the meeting with President Xi, confirmed to *Dawn* that the Chinese head of state has raised the issue of Chinese nationals' security in Pakistan. "He (President Xi) said security is important," the minister quoted the Chinese president as saying.

Meeting with Putin

Meanwhile, PM Shehbaz met President Putin and expressed gratitude to the Russian president for supporting Pakistan, saying that was viewed as 'a balancing act in the region'.

Both leaders agreed to further enhance the bilateral ties and coopera-

tion between the two countries in diverse fields.

PM Shehbaz said Pakistan respected Russia's ties with India and wanted to establish very strong relations of its own, which would be "supplementary and complementary".

Responding to Putin's invitation to attend the SCO Heads of Government Summit in November, the premier replied that he was looking forward to it.

President Putin said, "Pakistan has always been a traditional partner and remains as such in Asia, and we cherish these ties," adding that both sides had agreed to intensify their bilateral relations.

He noted that their bilateral trade needed to be enhanced and stressed taking steps to address the issue.

Khawaja Asif's outburst

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waterways and for allowing housing societies and hotels on riverbeds.

He also urged local government elections, criticising his own party's government in Punjab for failing to hold them.

He also blamed a "contracting company" for the flood devastation in his home constituency, Sialkot.

Responding to the defence minister's speech, Mr Abbasi said that those who had been a part of the system for the past 40 years were now criticising the system and "demanding local government elections".

Mr Abbasi took the floor when Mr Asif had already left the assembly hall after briefly attending the proceedings.

"Does a contractor dare to carry out substandard work and run away with money in Rawalpindi?" said Mr Abbasi, stating that it was the responsibility of the MNAs to keep a check on such activities.

He said blaming the entire bureaucracy was unfair, noting that the obsession with going viral in politics had become a "disease". "I have seen politicians resigning from the cabinet whenever a finger is raised at them. They left the ministry but stayed in the party," he said while indirectly suggesting the defence minister resign from the cabinet.

Federal Minister for Water Resources Mueen Wattoo said surveys were underway to assess flood-related losses, including damage to crops, livestock, and houses, with compensation to be provided to all affected families. He said estimates were being finalised to ensure timely financial assistance.

PTI's protest

Earlier, before leading a walkout, PTI leader Asad Qaiser said his party was standing with the flood victims and the leadership had already directed the party workers to visit the affected areas.

However, he said the party had decided to boycott the National Assembly proceedings to protest the policies of the "fascist" government, adding that the PTI members had already submitted their resignations from the standing committees.

Meanwhile, talking to reporters after his meeting with former prime minister Imran Khan at Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi, PTI Chairman Barrister Gohar Ali Khan said the party's decision to resign from standing committees was "final and irreversible".

Quoting the jailed former prime minister, he reportedly said that Imran Khan fully endorsed the party's decision to boycott by-elections and supported the resignations submitted by members from parliamentary committees.

13 lives lost, 35 hurt in suicide bombing

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of the National Party were also present, but escaped unhurt. However, former BNP MPA Mir Ahmed Nawaz Baloch and the party's central labour secretary Musa Jan were among those injured along with several party workers and supporters.

"We have received 13 bodies and 35 injured at the hospital," Dr Wasim Baig told *Dawn*, adding that the condition of several injured was critical.

Additional Chief Secretary (Home) Hamza Shafqaat, however, confirmed the death toll at 11 at that time. "So far, 11 people have lost their lives while over 30 are injured," he said, warning that the toll could rise as many were in serious condition.

Officials confirmed it was a suicide attack. The bomber detonated his explosives-laden jacket in the parking area as participants were leaving the meeting.

According to police, the explosion occurred about 15 minutes after the meeting ended, when crowds were dispersing.

"The blast took place in the parking area of the stadium," said BNP's senior vice president Sajid Tareen, adding that Sardar Mengal was still present at the time but later reached home safely.

Six vehicles, including bulletproof cars belonging to politicians, were damaged in the explosion. Mir Kabeer

Muhammad Shai survived as he was inside his bullet-proof vehicle when the blast occurred.

In a late-night statement, the Balochistan Home Department said a high-level investigation had been ordered. Authorities had collected evidence from the site, it said, adding that the injured were being provided the best possible medical care.

The deceased were identified as Muhammad Ishaq, Najeebullah, Shan, Muhammad Hanif, Madad Khan, Waqir Ahmed, Hafeez, Abdul Nabi, Nasarullah, Allah Bakhsh, Najeebullah, son of Asadullah, Allah Bakhsh and Muhammad Waqar.

Kech IED blast

Separately, five security personnel were martyred and three others injured on Tuesday when a convoy of security forces was targeted in a blast in the Buleda area of Kech district, near the Pakistan-Iran border.

Officials said the convoy of Frontier Corps personnel was passing near Babar Post when a powerful explosion struck one of the vehicles. Five soldiers lost their lives in the attack, while three others sustained injuries.

A senior security official confirmed that the blast occurred close to the convoy. He said an improvised explosive device (IED), planted by unidentified miscreants on the roadside, was detonated when the convoy was passing through the area.

Kalabagh Dam proposal

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addressed prior to its construction.

Political circles have been abuzz since then, with many struggling to decide whether to view his remarks as courageous or foolhardy.

In another interaction with journalists in the capital on Tuesday, CM Gandapur referred to international studies that favoured the construction of the controversial

Kalabagh Dam.

He said he had brought up the issue during a recent meeting of the Council of Common Interests (CCI), but claimed that some "foolish people" were against it.

Meanwhile, Punjab Information Minister Azma Bokhari on Tuesday said that for the first time, the Punjab government had found itself in agreement with the KP CM on this issue. Speaking at a presser, she said that

Punjab endorsed what Mr Gandapur had said about the Kalabagh Dam.

She said that Pakistan was among the countries most severely affected by climate change, making the construction of new dams a national necessity. She even suggested that all provinces should work on a joint action plan.

But the KP CM's statement had his own party puzzled. PTI leader and former National Assembly speaker Asad Qaiser told

Dawn Mr Gandapur's statement did not reflect party policy.

"The party has always made it clear that there should not be any controversial project in Pakistan. At the moment, there is need to strengthen the federation. The policy of Imran Khan is very clear, no such project can be started without consensus and the same has been suggested by the party's Central Executive Committee," he said.

Asked why he thought the chief minister would make such a statement, Mr Qaiser said that Gandapur should not have discussed the controversial issue.

"I cannot fathom how he has made the statement without discussing it within the party. I would say that it is his personal opinion and not party policy," he added.

Meanwhile, PTI Sindh leader Haleem Adil Sheikh called the proposal a "dead horse" which the party has never supported.

In a statement, Mr Sheikh said that jailed PTI founder Imran Khan had repeatedly opposed the controversial dam's construction during his tenure, making the party's stance clear. PPP leader Nisar Khuhro also expressed his annoyance over the KP CM's statement, recalling that Sindh, KP and Balochistan have opposed the project in the past.

Unity for survival

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THEY say adversity makes strange bedfellows. In Pakistan, even calamitous events struggle to do so. Floods have swept through KP, drowned swathes of Punjab after water was released from across the border, and displaced thousands. The destruction is immense. Yet the country's politicians, rather than rallying together, remain stuck in their habitual quarrels. A fleeting glimpse of unity came at the opening of the National Assembly session on Monday, when members suspended routine business to focus on the unfolding disaster. The spirit evaporated almost instantly. On the orders of Imran Khan, PTI legislators boycotted a scheduled NDMA briefing. Their absence turned what should have been a vital forum into yet another stage for political one-upmanship. The instinct to politicise calamity is not confined to one side. A couple of months ago, PTI lawmakers in Punjab tried to present the floods as proof of the provincial government's failures, only to face worse devastation in KP. And now, during the NA debate, ministers used up precious time to trumpet their own 'effective' responses or to cast blame on rivals and contractors. Defence Minister Khawaja Asif, while correctly pointing to encroachments and poor planning, also singled out a company in his home constituency, turning part of his speech into a political broadside. Even amid a shared tragedy, leaders reach for familiar tactics of point-scoring.

Nevertheless, the defence minister was right to call the situation a "man-made disaster". Successive governments have allowed hotels to sprout on riverbeds, sanctioned housing societies on floodplains and neglected to enforce building codes. Big dams remain mired in politics; small reservoirs and local drainage schemes, which could be completed in a year or two, are ignored. Weather-monitoring is abysmal: Pakistan has 85 stations to cover nearly 800,000 sq km, when thousands would be needed to meet international standards. No wonder the country lurches blindly from one storm to the next. There are precedents for doing better. During the 2010 floods, leaders did at least convene all-parties meetings and discussed creating an independent relief commission. The spirit was imperfect, but it showed some recognition that disaster could not be fought through mudslinging.

This year's floods ought to provoke similar realism. Unity is now a matter of survival. Politicians must come together to debate the hard questions: how to complete existing dam projects, build smaller water-storage structures, empower local governments and invest in forecasting capacity. They must also strengthen disaster-resilient infrastructure, enforce zoning laws against construction on riverbeds, upgrade drainage in cities, and expand social protection for displaced families. Climate change is redrawing the map. Three major floods in three provinces this summer alone should be warning enough. The waters have shown no partisanship. Neither should the politicians.

Terrorism upswing

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THE latest figures regarding the number of terrorist attacks in Pakistan indicate that rather than abating, militant insurgencies in KP and Balochistan continue to take a heavy toll. As per data compiled by the Pakistan Institute for Conflict Studies think tank, the country witnessed the highest number of militant attacks in a decade last month; at least 194 people were killed in 143 attacks, most of them security personnel and civilians, while over 230 were injured. KP saw the highest number of attacks, where banned groups such as the TTP have again become active, while Balochistan saw the second highest total, where separatist outfits like BLA have been waging a war against the state. It appears that if we continue on this troubling trajectory, last year's terrorism-related numbers may be surpassed; according to the PIPS think tank, there were over 520 terrorist attacks in 2024, claiming over 850 lives.

Considering these stark numbers, it is surprising why the outcry against terrorist violence is not louder at both the political and social levels. While there have been large demonstrations in KP — condemning terrorist violence and rejecting continued military operations — the rest of Pakistan seems oblivious to the terrorist threat. Perhaps this is because unlike previous waves, when terrorist groups repeatedly hit the country's urban centres, this time the violence is mostly limited to the 'peripheries', such as the merged tribal districts of KP, and Balochistan. Yet complacency will not buy the state or the public peace. Unless the state employs a holistic counterterrorism policy to permanently uproot the militant threat, this cycle of violence will continue. CT operations alone are not the sole solution; they need to be complemented by multi-sectoral solutions highlighted in NAP and NAP 2.0. People cannot be expected to suffer displacement due to military operations every decade or so, only to see militants return to areas previously cleared. Efforts to check infiltration from Afghanistan must be paired with internal operations to permanently secure territory. Moreover, in Balochistan, along with countering separatist violence, the political process needs to be promoted to help defeat the insurgency. The numbers are very unsettling, and if terrorist groups are not stopped now, they will start looking to expand their areas of operation. The civilian wing of the ruling set-up must clearly enunciate what concrete CT steps it has in mind.

Reduced wheat acreage

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THE FAO's assessment of Pakistan's latest wheat crop is both reassuring and worrying. On the one hand, it celebrates a harvest 5pc higher than the five-year average; on the other, it highlights the troubling fact that wheat acreage has shrunk by 6.5pc as farmers abandon the staple crop for more profitable alternatives. The reduction in wheat acreage was not unexpected. The government's abolition of the minimum support price and falling rates during the sowing season were among the main reasons why some farmers switched to what they saw as more profitable crops. It was an economic decision: why grow something that yields lower returns? The report notes the woes of wheat farmers from the rain-fed dry regions who constitute nearly a fifth of all staple growers. While canal-irrigated areas are enjoying above-average yields, farmers from the dry regions are vulnerable to drought and water shortages. Their losses can be significant, forcing them to shift to drought-resistant crops.

That said, the declining wheat acreage does not necessarily mean that the government's policy of withdrawing itself from the market is flawed or misguided. It was long overdue. However, it is a sobering reminder that piecemeal economic reforms risk destabilising the agriculture markets to the detriment of both growers and consumers. The decline in acreage demands that policymakers go beyond the abolition of the support price if they want to make wheat profitable for farmers. Only a functioning and well-regulated market can deliver market stability and ensure profitability for growers — particularly smallholders. Farmers need access to small soft loans for inputs and mechanisation, insurance protection from the vagaries of the weather, training in modern farming and irrigation techniques, removal of exploitative middlemen and stronger linkages with global markets through a liberal wheat trade regime. Unless the reforms are taken to their logical conclusion, we will continue to see risks to food security and rural livelihoods.



Multilateral world order

The Tianjin summit reinforced China's leading role in the emerging international order.

IT WAS the largest gathering of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, with leaders of Eurasian nations seeking to establish a more just and equitable multilateral system as an alternative to a crumbling West-dominated world order. The recently concluded SCO summit in the Chinese city of Tianjin brought together countries with competing interests in times of great turmoil in global governance.

Initially formed as a security cooperation group over two decades ago, the SCO has evolved into a formidable forum for trade and economic development. Described as 'SCO-Plus', the conference was attended by more than 20 heads of state and government, as well as leaders of international organisations. The Tianjin summit reinforced China's leading role in the emerging multilateral international order.

In his speech, President Xi Jinping called for "equal and orderly multipolarisation". The Chinese leader stressed the need for the organisation to work towards a "more just and equitable global governance system" and urged regional leaders to shun a "Cold War mentality". It was pointed out that member states faced complicated security and development challenges in a "chaotic and intertwined" world. These remarks set the tone of the conference. His speech indicated China's emphasis on geo-economics and connectivity.

As per media reports, "The organisation covers approximately 24 per cent of global land area and 42pc of the world's population, with member states accounting for roughly one-quarter of global GDP and trade increasing nearly 100-fold in two decades." China's trade with SCO members, observers and dialogue partners reportedly totalled \$890 billion in 2024. Donald Trump's reckless trade war has massively increased SCO's potential, as the bloc provides an alternative to America's economic domination.

The conference also brought the leaders of Pakistan and India face-to-face for the first time after their four-day conflict in May that had pushed the two nuclear-armed nations close to a wider conflagration. The tension was palpable with the two leaders not even shaking hands, let alone any possibility of meeting on the sidelines.

Pakistan's offer for a dialogue on all disputed matters between the two countries had gone unheeded by the Indian prime minister.

Without taking names, both leaders accused the other of perpetrating terrorist activities in their respective countries. New Delhi has hardened its position and does not want any bilateral talks with Islamabad after it was humiliated during its military action against Pakistan. India's belligerence remains the main source of tension, hampering regional economic and trade cooperation. There seems to be no change in its stance despite foreign policy setbacks.

However, the conference provided an opportunity for China and India to ease the tensions in their relationship. It was the first trip of the Indian prime minister to China in seven years. Relations between the world's two most populous nations remained strained after bloody border clashes in 2019 following India's unilateral and illegal decision to annex the disputed state of Jammu and Kashmir and declare Ladakh as federal territory.

Although a ceasefire has been in place for some time, other issues have continued to strain their relationship. India has been part of a US-led anti-China coalition in the Indo-Pacific region. But the latest dispute with the Trump administration on trade tariffs seems to have forced India to mend fences with China. Interestingly, the 50 per cent tariff on exports to the US had come into force just before the summit. Once America's so-called strategic ally, India now faces some of the highest tariffs imposed by the US. This factor, together with political reasons, has caused relations to sour between Washington and Delhi.

Although the Chinese and Indian leaders agreed they were not "rivals but partners in development", unresolved issues remain between them, which can widen the existing trust deficit. These include the border dispute, which the Chinese president indicated should be put aside to focus on improved trade and economic relations.

Interestingly, despite their strained relations over the past years, trade between the two countries in 2024-2025 totalled \$118bn, though with India's trade deficit with China reaching \$99.2bn. The thaw in their relations has already resulted

in the resumption of direct flights between the two countries and improved business environment. But China's strategic relations with Pakistan continue to cast a shadow over any further breakthrough.

The summit also reinforced Russia's return to the global stage after being ostracised by the West for invading Ukraine. President Putin blamed the West for triggering the war. The Russian president has also been invited to the military parade in Beijing this week to commemorate the 80th anniversary of the victory of the World Anti-Fascist War (World War II) and the founding of the United Nations. "It is a milestone prompting us to remember the past and create a better future together," declared President Xi.

The gathering of leaders and observers from across Eurasia reflected the emerging alignment in the shifting sands of regional geopolitics. The bloc represents the emerging power of the Global South, which is challenging the unjust Western international global order.

The Tianjin Declaration, issued after the two-day parleys, reaffirmed the commitment to sustainable international peace and called for joint efforts to counter traditional and new security challenges. While resolving to fight against terrorism, separatism and extremism, the conference recognised the leading role of sovereign states and their competent authorities in countering terrorist and extremist threats.

The conference also adopted a 10-year SCO Development Strategy, which "defines the priority tasks and main directions for deepening multifaceted cooperation in the interests of ensuring peace and stability, development and prosperity in the SCO space".

After the summit concluded, President Xi had a bilateral meeting with Pakistan's prime minister and his delegation in Beijing, reaffirming the strategic and economic partnership between the two countries. They also agreed to initiate the second phase of CPEC. The SCO provides a great opportunity for Pakistan's economic development. ■



Flawed monetary policy

AFTER reducing the policy rate to 11 per cent in May 2025, the State Bank of Pakistan's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has since kept the rate unchanged in its meetings on June 16 and July 30.

This decision appears imprudent, especially amid low inflation — 3.2 per cent in June and 4.1pc in July — and sub-optimal growth. The monetary policy statement issued on July 30 noted that year-on-year inflation is expected to remain largely within the 5-7pc target range in FY26. The MPC noted positive key developments since its last meeting. First, the SBP's FX reserves crossed \$14 billion on the back of improved financial inflows and a current account surplus. Second, the recent upgrade in Pakistan's sovereign credit rating led to a decline in Eurobond yields and narrowed CDS (credit default swaps) spreads in international markets. It also acknowledged the government's fiscal consolidation efforts, which resulted in a primary surplus in FY25 and an expected surplus of 2.4pc of GDP in FY26.

While the SBP notes positive trends in the economy and broadly sees things in the targeted or sustainable ranges, it has kept the policy rate unchanged amid sluggish economic activity. With inflation projected to remain within target, fiscal discipline in place, stable exchange rate despite heavy buying by the central bank to augment reserves, and the projected current account deficit to stay between 0-1pc of GDP in FY26, maintaining the policy rate at 11pc is difficult to justify — particularly when growth remains well below potential. In FY25, both large-scale manufacturing and agriculture posted negative growth.

Looking ahead, the floods make it unlikely that the already modest projected growth of 3.5pc in FY26 will be achieved. Headline inflation eased unexpectedly to 3pc in August 2025. In the aftermath of the floods, price spikes in perishable food items are likely, while demand-side inflation pressures are expected to be relatively contained.

Pakistan is caught in a low-growth, low-investment trap, and the SBP's monetary stance is doing little to change that. By keeping the policy rate and exchange rate artificially high, the central bank is effectively stifling economic activity. High financing and production costs — driven by elevated interest rates and energy prices — are eroding business competitiveness, discouraging investment and undermining growth.

Under the SBP Act, the bank's primary mandate is to maintain price stability. Monetary pol-

icy must be data-driven, and the policy rate should be set based on forward-looking inflation projections. When the MPC itself acknowledges that inflation has declined and is expected to stay within the target band, holding the policy rate at 11pc is unjustifiable.

Over the past decade, the SBP has adopted a more robust monetary policy framework aligned with inflation targeting. It has benefited from governance reforms, a clearer mandate, greater operational independence, both de jure and de facto, and improved transparency and accountability. The statutory MPC, established in 2015 to shield the central bank from political interference, now operates without any government representation.

Monetary policy must navigate a world shaped by a multiplicity of shocks.

Yet, despite its independence from domestic political pressures, the MPC appears overly influenced by the IMF, whose advice often leans towards excessive contraction, even when inflation is falling and real sector performance is deteriorating.

The SBP should aim to maintain a reasonably positive real interest rate — not an excessively positive one that strangles growth. Stabilisation without economic growth is becoming Pakistan's new normal — an unsustainable path that only deepens unemployment, inequality and low human development. As the apex decision-making body, the MPC must broaden its perspective and consider the wider impact of its decisions on all segments of the economy, not just exporters, importers or the financial sector.

Now, let's look at how global developments might impact our monetary policy. The global impact of ongoing tariff wars adds nuance to inflation dynamics. For countries facing higher tariffs on their exports, the result is typically a negative demand shock, exerting mild downward pressure on inflation. In contrast, for countries imposing much higher tariffs, notably the US, the tariffs will likely act more as an adverse supply shock, boosting inflation while lowering growth. So, Pakistan could potentially expect a better inflation outlook.

Moreover, in a more turbulent external environment, foreign exchange intervention can help address disorderly market conditions that undermine financial stability. This can improve macroeconomic outcomes as well as lower financial stability risks. However, it is important that FX intervention is not used to reduce exchange rate volatility per se, or to target a particular level of the exchange rate.

Lastly, there is a high premium on further strengthening policy frameworks to continue building resilience in a more shock-prone environment.

Clarity of communication has become more critical than ever. Effective communication about the central bank's reaction function — in qualitative terms — is likely to be useful in helping better anchor inflation expectations and thus improve trade-offs.

Improved governance can increase public confidence that the central bank will have latitude to achieve its objectives. Central banks will make mistakes — no forecast is perfect. But what must be clear is that any deviation from target is the result of uncertainty, not political interference.

The SBP must adapt its policy strategies to focus more on the distribution of outcomes than the model outlook, and to take more account of risk management considerations. Monetary policy must navigate a world shaped by a multiplicity of shocks — some persistent, some temporary, and some with offsetting effects on inflation where it is difficult to assess the net impact. The SBP should continue taking steps to revise its frameworks to move away from excessive reliance on central forecasts. This can be facilitated by increasing the use of scenario analysis in decision-making.

Monetary policy must remain data dependent. As the global economic order is reset and uncertainty prevails, the SBP should avoid unwarranted gradualism. If inflation pressures decline, it must respond quickly using policy instruments to tackle economic stagnation and unemployment. The road ahead may have many unforeseen turns, which calls for further strengthening financial and fiscal resilience and navigating with monetary policy clarity, credibility and discipline. ■

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1975 | Fifty years
ago

Religious schools

ISLAMABAD: The Government has absolutely no plan to take over or nationalise the religious schools in the country, the Minister for Haj and Religious Affairs told a Press conference here this afternoon [Sept 2]. Referring to the present campaign being carried on by the Opposition leader, Maulana Mufti Mahmud, and some of his followers, the Minister said contrary to Mufti Sahib's allegations the Government or any of its departments had not issued any notice to any of the religious schools in this regard. In fact, he added, the Prime Minister and he himself, in private talk with Mufti Mahmud had explained to him very clearly that the Government had no plan to take over religious schools. — Islamabad Bureau

[Meanwhile, as reported by news agencies from Mecca,] Prime Minister Bhutto and members of his entourage performed Umra at the Khaanae Kaaba here tonight [Sept 2]. The Prime Minister kissed the Sung-e-Aswad engraved in a corner of the Khaanae Kaaba. Tears welled up in his eyes and he stood motionless for a moment, praying for the strength of the Muslim World and the Pakistani nation. Mr Bhutto arrived in Jeddah this evening after making a visit to Medina Munawarah for Ziarat.

Par value of rupee

KARACHI: Lively interest is being evinced in Karachi financial and economic circles in the outcome of the deliberations of the International Monetary Fund which will consider the par value of the Pakistani rupee when it meets in Paris next week. ... [E]xperts of the IMF have been examining the question for the past two months in Washington where Pakistan representatives have been assisting them with all necessary data. ...

Karachi financial circles strongly aver that the par value of the Pakistani rupee ... is based on the soundest possible economic foundations. ... Competent Karachi opinion ... discounts the wild rumours ... that the IMF is likely to recommend at least a partial de-valuation of the Pakistani rupee. Non-official experts ... point out ... the overwhelming weight of economic factors would clearly demand that ... Pakistan ... remain unmoved in the decision which they took in September 1949.

... [A]n authoritative source ... [said] that any other course would be economically disastrous when "the Pakistani rupee has withstood all the economic tests and emerged triumphant". — Financial correspondent



Chinese checkers

AFICIONADOS of spectacular martial displays will no doubt find today's military parade in Beijing considerably more impressive than the one that marked 250 years of the US Army (as well as Donald Trump's birthday) in Washington not too long ago.

Narendra Modi won't be there, perhaps because saluting China's military prowess just five years after border clashes, and barely four months after Chinese technology gave Pakistan an edge in the post-Pahalgam hostilities, would not have played well at home. But at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Tianjin over the weekend, he was holding hands with Vladimir Putin and Xi Jinping on what was the Indian prime minister's first visit to China in seven years.

Apart from talks with Xi, he spent more than 45 minutes in Putin's limousine. Obviously, we don't know what they discussed. There was never much of a chance that Modi (if he was so inclined) could sway the Russian president from his aggression against Ukraine. The Chinese leader, meanwhile, held out the prospect of partnership in place of rivalry, and Modi expressed no disagreement.

This could be notched up as yet another triumph for the first seven months of Trump's presidency. The non-alignment that India's first PM judiciously favoured has left its marks, notwithstanding all of the relatively recent hostility against 'Nehruvian socialism'. While maintaining cordial ties with three US administrations, Jawaharlal Nehru was also attached to the idea of friendship with the Soviet Union and China. There have been fractures over the decades with Washington and Beijing, but the Moscow connection has survived the demise of the USSR.

Russia, however, wasn't a key source of crude oil until the sanctions following its attack on Ukraine. The irony is that until last year the US pretty much encouraged India to purchase Russian crude to maintain oil prices, and had no objection to the refined product being sold on to Europe or America, so that they could claim they weren't buying it from Russia. The largest refinery belongs to Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries, which helps to explain why a sudden halt to Russian imports would be a non-starter for the crony capitalism that has helped to sustain the BJP regime.

Previous US presidents wooed India as a counter-balance to China, as part of a strategy that has only persuaded the latter to extend its military prowess. Trump presumably knows that China imports more Russian crude than India, yet his aides have described the Ukraine conflict as 'Modi's war' and derided India as a

'laundromat' for Russia. That's absurd, given that Moscow would be disinclined to shift its aggressive stance as long as Beijing and Delhi are on board. The Ukraine war would not screech to a halt if India stopped purchasing Russian oil.

It might be different if China withdrew its support from Russia, but that too is unlikely. Inadvertently or otherwise, the US has facilitated rapprochement between India and China. '*Hindi-Cheeni bhai bhai*' might remain a historical memory, but the South Asian region would no doubt benefit from unexpected bonhomie between the world's two most populous powers. The days of 'Howdy Modi' and 'Namaste Trump' seem to be long gone. Around the time of Trump's second inauguration, a global poll indicated that India was among the very few Global South nations that saw his return to power as positive. Opinions have been shifting, though, and even the 52 per cent of Indians who approved of Trumpianism in June might be differently inclined after the 50pc tariffs threatening to strangle India's economy.

China knows how to play the long game.

That's yet another obstacle in the path of India's economic illusions, and it remains to be seen whether a prospective partnership with China might prove transformative. But Modi is

also struggling domestically, after the disappointing last election and credible accusations of fraud. That may seem Trumpian in some ways, but the US and India are very different entities.

Both Modi and Trump benefit from largely ineffectual oppositions. That might change, and the aftermath could remain troublesome. It must be said, though, that Modi's reported refusal to chat with Trump over the phone was more assertive than Pakistan's deference to Washington. Neither side has offered a credible explanation for why the war stopped. Whatever the details, the outcome stretches beyond regional circumstances.

China's transcendence might be a long time coming, but, unlike Trump, Xi knows how to play the long game. Could a better world order emerge? It's not impossible, but the scant mention in the Tianjin agenda of the genocide in Gaza and beyond serves as yet another reminder that trade trumps transgressions against human rights. China's trajectory as a US rival remains shrouded in mystery, but Trump might solve it sooner than we expect. ■



Crypto moment?

CRYPTOCURRENCIES, best understood as digital assets, remain a niche segment within the global financial system despite much recent hype. For digital assets to gain serious traction, they must prove their value through solid use cases that enhance the existing ecosystem. There are signs that this may finally be happening as reality begins to catch up with the hype. What does this suggest for the future of Pakistan's financial markets?

In Pakistan, the first official stance came in 2018 when the State Bank of Pakistan warned the public that digital assets "are neither recognised as legal tender nor authorised by SBP for issuance, sale, purchase, exchange, or investment". Fast forward to March 2025, when the government established the Pakistan Crypto Council, chaired by the finance minister, signalling a significant shift in attitude.

By July 2025, the Virtual Assets Ordinance was enacted, creating the Pakistan Virtual Assets Regulatory Authority to frame legal, licensing and regulatory policies for the sector. It now seems likely that Pakistan is moving towards adopting digital assets, making it important to understand their implications.

The underlying technology for cryptocurrencies is Blockchain: a shared, secure, transparent, immutable, and decentralised digital ledger of transactions. Blockchain offers many potential applications beyond cryptocurrencies.

Cryptocurrencies date back only to 2009 with the launch of Bitcoin. Today, thousands of cryptocurrencies exist, ranging from legitimate projects to scams. Bitcoin remains the largest, with a current market capitalisation of around \$2.5 trillion, five times that of the second-largest, Ethereum. Unlike fiat currencies issued by sovereign governments, cryptocurrencies have no central issuing authority. This decentralisation means they operate without banks or other financial intermediaries.

Public attention has largely focused on Bitcoin and a few others, mainly due to their extreme price volatility and the fortunes made or lost by speculators. However, for cryptocurrencies to become a meaningful part of the financial system, they must offer use cases beyond trading and speculation. We can assess this by comparing them to the traditional roles of currency: as a medium of exchange, a unit of account, and a store of value. Let's examine two use cases.

Firstly, cryptocurrencies can serve as a faster, cheaper payment system. Current bank-based payment systems, especially for cross-border transactions, are slow and costly due to multiple intermediaries. Cryptocurrencies enable instant, direct

payments between parties without banks. However, for this to work, cryptocurrencies require broader, potentially universal, acceptance. US companies like Ripple, which backs the cryptocurrency XRP, are positioning themselves as efficient alternatives for cross-border payments, even seeking collaboration with banks. Ripple's July 2025 application for a US banking licence highlights this evolving relationship.

Secondly, cryptocurrencies are sometimes viewed as a 'digital gold', offering a store of value separate from government-issued fiat currencies.

This narrative has gained ground amid concerns over fiat currency debasement due to excessive monetary expansion, especially following the 2007-08 global financial crisis and the 2020 Covid-19 pandemic. Cryptocurrencies which have capped supplies (Bitcoin's cap is 21 million coins), are seen as better preserves of value. However, this is not true for all cryptocurrencies.

The biggest challenge remains their high price volatility. Stability of value is essential for any asset to

The biggest challenge remains the high price volatility.

fully function as money. Stablecoins, special cryptocurrencies pegged 1:1 to high-quality assets, offer a solution. The US passage in July 2025 of the GENIUS Act regulates stablecoins, requiring full

asset backing. Stablecoin issuance is booming, with commercial banks like JPMorgan, the largest US bank, launching their own versions.

Central banks are also exploring digital assets via Central Bank Digital Currencies, government-issued digital fiat money. The SBP confirmed in July 2025 that it is working on a CBDC.

Notably, the US opposes a government digital currency, citing concerns about citizens' privacy.

So, is this Pakistan's crypto moment? The pace of developments in 2025 is unprecedented for a government initiative. The timing is intriguing, coming shortly after a US administration pursued a digital asset agenda. Pakistan has an opportunity to study global trends carefully, prioritise citizen welfare, and establish strong, thoughtful regulation.

Reports indicate substantial cryptocurrency trading and investment by Pakistani citizens. The government and regulators need to catch up. ■

The writer is a member of the Economic Advisory Group.
eag.org.pk

Power theft is the rise

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ELECTRICITY theft, which continues to worsen the energy crisis and deepen the country's circular debt, has now crossed unprecedented levels. Pakistan's installed power generation capacity is over 46,000MW, while the actual consumption ranges from 8,000MW in winter to 30,000MW during peak summer.

This discrepancy is not due to lack of capacity, but because of the massive losses in the distribution system, particularly non-technical losses caused by theft and meter tampering.

Traditional enforcement methods have proven ineffective. The time has come to embrace artificial intelligence (AI) to detect and curb theft more efficiently. India and Brazil are among the countries that have successfully adopted such models.

According to a World Bank report, smart meters and AI-based consumption analytics in Delhi cut losses from 53 per cent to under 8pc. In Brazil, machine learning and geospatial analysis have been able to detect electricity theft with over 90pc accuracy. South Africa has also been testing AI-based solutions to flag meter bypassing in informal settlements.

Smart meters, AI-powered anomaly detection, and monitoring based on geographic information system (GIS) are some of the tools that identify theft in real time, reduce the need for manual inspections, and recover billions in lost revenue.

The relevant authorities in Pakistan should prioritise AI integration in the distribution network as a long-term strategy to reform Pakistan's power sector.

Muhammad Faraz Qureshi
Hyderabad



Twisted equality

WHILE the notion of gender equality largely serves the cause of the majority of women in society, it surely burdens a few who struggle to strike an ideal work-life balance simply because of the self-inflicted pressure of being 'equal'. Given a chance, such women would opt out of this race to attain 'empowerment' as defined by a certain school of thought.

The burden of attending to the demands of work life, raising children, and taking care of everything domestic can be exhausting, and it often is. The actual freedom is one's ability to do what one wants to, not what a certain segment of society wants one to.

The twisted sense of freedom is spoiling the lives of many women. It is not uncommon in family gatherings to hear stories of exhaustion being shared among working women.

By their own account, most of them started off in search of empowerment, but then gradually their income became so indispensable to the household that they just had to go with the flow.

It is like being shifted from one cage to another, one frustrated working woman told me recently. We need to give due weightage to such stories.

On their part, such women would do a lot of good if they could revisit their understanding of freedom and equality.

KE accountability

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K-Electric (KE) has been supplying electricity to our apartment block through its Memon-I and Memon-II pole-mounted transformers (PMTs) for long. Due to unpaid bills of a colony behind the apartment block, whose electricity comes from the same PMTs, the KE shuts down both the PMTs often and for long hours. This is in addition to the regular loadshedding, which is, of course, unannounced.

The KE even changed feeder of both PMTs from medium-loss feeder (Abdul Mannan) to very high-loss feeder (Ismailia Platinum) around six months ago. When all the residents of our apartment block cleared their dues and went to the KE Integrated Business Centre (IBC) at Garden in the last week of June, the officials there forced them to have their own PMT installed by paying the relevant amount, or to continue facing the current long hours of loadshedding.

This is, without any doubt or debate, a highly unethical act on the part of the KE, which is forcing the residents to 'buy' a PMT instead of taking action against colony residents for power theft and unpaid bills. The matter surely deserves the urgent attention of the National Electric Power Regulatory Authority (Nepra).

M. Hammad Rafique
Karachi

Farm economy can do the trick for us

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PAKISTAN, as is known far and wide, is predominantly an agricultural country where nearly 37 per cent of the labour force is directly associated with the agriculture sector. The agro-economy remains the backbone of Pakistan's financial system, contributing approximately 19pc to the national gross domestic product (GDP).

Despite such significance, the country's farming practices remain outdated and inefficient. This inefficiency results in poor productivity, making it difficult for farmers to meet the demands of a growing population, or to compete across global markets.

To tackle these challenges, awareness campaigns and training programmes must be prioritised. Public-private partnerships must step forward to organise awareness seminars and capacity-building workshops at the grassroots level.

Undoubtedly, these events can play a pivotal role in educating farmers about modern irrigation techniques, like drip irrigation, sprinkler systems, and the use of climate-smart agricultural practices that significantly enhance productivity and water conservation, enabling a sustainable agricultural growth.

A successful example of agricultural advancement can be seen in the Shah Abdul Latif University in Khairpur, which has established a state-of-the-art Date Palm Research Institute (DPRI). Khairpur is renowned for its dates, and this dedicated institution is helping revolutionise the date industry by researching and cultivating multiple species of date palms.

By employing these and other scientific methods and farmer collaboration, the DPRI is enabling local farmers to irrigate

date palms more efficiently, and to increase their yields considerably.

The Agriculture University of Tandojam, being a major stakeholder in professional education relevant to agriculture, must replicate such successful initiatives by developing specialised research centres for various crops, such as wheat, rice, sugarcane and cotton, and fruits like mangoes and bananas.

These centres could become hubs for innovation where soil health management, pest control, crop rotation, and water-efficient practices would be researched and then implemented in the field through training programmes.

Pakistan's agriculture has immense potential to contribute significantly to foreign exchange earnings through the export of surplus produce, especially if backed by technology and research.

Pakistan is already the fourth-largest producer of mangoes and the fifth-largest producer of sugarcane, yet its exports remain limited due to post-harvest losses and low productivity.

By adopting targeted research and innovation across all aspects of agriculture, the country can ensure food security, and also boost exports, thus strengthening the economy at large. Bridging the current gap between research institutions and farmers is now a necessity, not an option.

Sajjad Hussain Cheehani
Agra, Sindh

reconsider the said decision and reinstate the 50pc travel concession at the earliest. Such a measure would go a long way towards alleviating the hardships that are now being faced by differently-abled people and senior citizens, and would reflect our nation's compassion and inclusivity.

Aqib Raza
Lahore

Travel concession

THE recent curtailment of the 50 per cent discount on public transport, especially railways, has added to the troubles of the differently-abled persons and elderly citizens. This concession was not merely a financial relief, it was a necessary support enabling such individuals to commute for medical treatment, education, employment and other social activities. The financial burden is making things difficult for these people.

The removal of the facility has already started to affect their daily lives. They are forced to limit essential commute or depend entirely on others. This is not a matter of affordability alone; it compromises the dignity and independence of these people.

Public transport is a lifeline for these persons, and restoring the discount would reaffirm society's commitment to equality and care for its most vulnerable members.

The relevant authorities should urgently

► **BLOCKED ROADS:** I wish to highlight the growing menace of encroachments on major roads in Karachi, especially in North Nazimabad, Water Pump, Nagan Chowrangi and Sohrab Goth where pushcart vendors continue to occupy entire lanes throughout the day as well as till late in the evening. This constant encroachment narrows the roads, causing severe traffic jams that obstruct even ambulances dealing with emergencies. Sadly, no effective action is visible from the authorities. The administration must urgently clear these roads and ensure strict monitoring afterwards for the safety and convenience of people.

Dr Asim Mubashir
Karachi

► **GAS SHORTAGE:** Gas crisis in the country has turned into a year-round struggle for almost everyone. In many areas of Islamabad, Rawalpindi, Lahore and Karachi, families cannot cook food at regular times, even during summers, because of low or zero gas pressure. Citizens pay their bills regularly, but are left to suffer in the wake of severe gas crisis, while mismanagement, line losses and lack of long-term planning continue to plague the system. They are forced to buy expensive LPG cylinders or switch to electrical appliances, which further raises their monthly expenses. As such, The situation shows a complete failure of energy governance. The government must stop handing out seasonal excuses, and instead work on fairer distribution, investment in critical infrastructure, and accountability of gas-supply companies.

Muhammad Anfal
Islamabad

► **A CRITICAL QUESTION:** Several colleges and university buildings in the country stand deserted. Can we blame the youth for not caring about education? When making a short video can bring more money than years of hard work, they think there is always something better and more productive to do than spending time in a classroom. This is a big crisis, not just for education, but for society at large. We must settle on a course of action before it gets too late to do anything.

Dr M. Khan Sangi
Jamshoro

Four killed in rain-related incidents across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

Several Peshawar neighbourhoods flooded

Dawn Report

PESHAWAR: Four people were killed and four suffered injuries as rains lash several parts of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa on Tuesday. Several neighbourhoods of Peshawar were flooded.

Provincial Disaster Management Authority said two people were killed in Khyber tribal district, while Buner and Tank districts reported one death each in roof collapse and mudslide incidents.

Several parts of the provincial capital, including Hayatabad, Regi and Warsak Road, were inundated due to flooding in the Budhni nullah.

Spokesman for Rescue 1122 Bilal Ahmad Faizi told Dawn that rescue workers evacuated at least 200 people from those areas.

He said that last night's rain caused floodwaters to enter houses in Arbab Cottages Colony, Madina Colony, Regi Model Town and the surroundings of Budhni Bridge, leaving many families stranded.

Mr Faizi said Rescue 1122 teams safely evacuated women, children and elderly persons in special boats.

He said children stranded in a school bus, families trapped in their homes and people stuck in flooded streets were also rescued.

Residents said basements in most houses in those areas were inundated.

Also, Peshawar's Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) services remained suspended for several hours due to inundation of the corridor.

TransPeshawar, the operator of the mass transit, said in a statement that all BRT services had been suspended due to the inundation of corridor and feeder routes. The bus service on the main corridor was restored in the afternoon.

In Khyber tribal district, 12 houses were damaged, while several electricity poles were uprooted.

The flash floods washed away link roads in several localities of Landi Kotal and Jamrud.

Police and Rescue 1122 personnel said most houses were damaged in Malagori sub-tehsil of Jamrud as floodwater entered several rooms. Over a dozen electricity poles were also uprooted.

In Landi Kotal, floodwaters damaged Dargai-Kam Shalman



(CLOCKWISE FROM TOP) Rescue 1122 personnel shift people to safer place in a boat after rainwater entered their houses in a neighbourhood on Warsak Road, Peshawar, on Tuesday. Waist-high rainwater inundates a street in Budhani area of Peshawar. Clearance operation under way after landslides triggered by rain blocked the Wana-Gomal Zam Road in South Waziristan. — White Star/Dawn/APP

Road. Traffic to the Sheen Pokhara in Loe Shalman was also suspended due to landslides.

The rainwater inundated the children's park adjacent to Hamza Baba's mausoleum, with several houses suffering damage in Peero Khel, Angor Bagh and Ugda Darra localities.

The Afghan families bound for their country were seen stranded on roadsides, with no proper shelter to protect them from heavy rainfall.

The rain also lashed several parts of Mohmand tribal district. Flash floods in upper parts of the district caused widespread destruction in Safi, Baizai and Khewazai subdivisions.

Khakh Bazaar in Safi tehsil was the worst-hit area, with doz-

ens of shops, warehouses and factories swept away or badly damaged by the deluge, according to assistant commissioner Usman Hamza.

Meanwhile, Baizai sub-division also received heavy rain, affecting Mazari Chena, Lakhkar Kalay, Koda Khel, Spinky Tangi and Khwreena areas in Baizai tehsil along with Kong, Khadikhel, Kaka Kor and Babi Kore in Khewazai tehsil.

Assistant commissioner of Baizai Noman Hafeez and tehsildar went to those areas to monitor the situation.

Mr Hafeez said two arteries in Khewazai, including Kung Village Road and Attokhel-Attra Bazar Road, were severely damaged by floodwaters, while Kuzo

Kass bridge was washed away by floodwaters. An 11KV electricity transmission line was destroyed in Soor Daag village of Khewazai.

Floodwaters also inundated residential areas in Safi, Khewaizai and neighbouring Michnai, Prachavi bazaar, Kado Koor and Shaheed Banda localities.

Multiple houses collapsed or were damaged, while crops were ruined. Key roads and a bridge in Khewazai were washed away, hampering rescue and relief efforts.

In the Lower South Waziristan tribal district, torrential rains triggered landslides at several points of the Wana-Gomal Zam Road near Sheen Kai, bringing traffic to a halt.

Additional deputy commissioner Khalid Qayyum said a debris clearance operation was launched with the help of heavy machinery.

Officials of the district administration said the road closure caused long queues of vehicles on both sides, with patients and commuters suffering the most.

The transporters union said traffic was temporarily diverted to the Wana-Jandola route to the people's misery.

Heavy rainfall was also reported in Kohat, Orakzai and several other parts of the province. The PMD said Kakul recorded 38mm of rainfall, Upper Dir 27, Saidu Sharif 20, Peshawar nine and Takhtbai seven.

Govt dispatches aid for Afghan quake victims

Page 8

Bureau Report

PESHAWAR: The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa government here on Tuesday handed over 35 trucks of relief goods to the Afghan authorities for the earthquake victims of Afghanistan.

A statement issued here said the relief items were handed over at an event at the Provincial Disaster Management Authority headquarters. KP chief secretary Shahab Ali Shah and director general PDMA Asfandiyar Khattak were present on the occasion. Afghan counsel general in Peshawar Hafiz Muhibullah Shakir also attended the event.

The relief items included two trucks of medicines, 500 winterised tents, 500 family sized tents, 500 blankets besides other items.

Chief secretary Shahab Ali Shah on the occasion expressed his grief over the losses caused by the earthquake and said that the KP government stood with its Afghan brethren in this hour of need.

Afghan counsel general Muhibullah Shakir appreciated the KP government's gesture and said that it would help strengthen ties between both the countries.

JI protests killing of worker in mortar shell attack

Page 8

By Our Correspondent

BAJAUR: The Jamaat-i-Islami local chapter here on Tuesday staged a protest demonstration against killing of one of its workers in a mortar shell attack in Lowi Mamund tehsil a day earlier.

Besides the JI activists, scores of workers of other political parties and peace activists also attended the demonstration held in Inayat Kallay Bazaar. The protesters condemned the incident, saying that Muhammad Yar was an innocent person who lost his life when a mortar shell fired from unspecified direction hit his house in Laghari area on Monday.

JI senior leaders Haji Sardar Khan, Maulana Sanaullah, Ghulam Rehman, Irfan Janbaz, Muhammad Younis, Maulana Farman Ansari, PML-N district president Gul Kareem Khan, Nawagai tehsil council chairman and PTI senior leader Dr Khalilur Rehman, PML-N leader Muhammad Ismail and others addressed the protest and expressed deep concern over the killing of Muhammad Yar.

The speakers termed Muhammad Yar's killing unacceptable, noting that he was an innocent civilian and sole bread earner for his family. They demanded a thorough investigation into Muhammad Yar's killing and called for concrete measures to ensure the safety and security of innocent civilians and their properties in the ongoing anti-terrorism operation in Lowi Mamund and War Mamund tehsils.

Many of the speakers also demanded an early and result-oriented conclusion of the ongoing operation in the region to bring a durable peace in the district.

CM orders emergency measures to arrest dengue spread

Page 8

PESHAWAR: The chief minister of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Ali Amin Gandapur, has taken

urgent notice of the potential spread of dengue fever following the recent spell of rains in the province and directed all the departments concerned to launch emergency anti-dengue measures without delay.

The chief minister's secretariat has issued a formal communiqué to all the divisional commissioners, deputy commissioners and relevant departments, underscoring that stagnant rain water is providing breeding grounds for dengue mosquitoes which must be taken care

of through immediate cleanliness and control drives.

The directives call for special attention to be given to the drainage of accumulated water at public places, construction sites, markets, schools, government offices and sewerage lines.

The health department has been instructed to ensure that hospitals are fully equipped in advance, with the availability of medicines, diagnostic facilities and treatment arrangements for dengue patients, while an inte-

grated system is to be put in place for effective monitoring and timely reporting of dengue cases across the province.

The local government bodies have been made responsible for regular spraying and larvicide measures in all vulnerable areas.

Furthermore, the information department has been tasked, in collaboration with the health department and district administrations, to launch a large-scale awareness campaign to educate the public about preventive

measures against dengue. This campaign will utilise print, electronic and social media platforms extensively.

Citizens have been urged to drain stagnant water in and around their homes, keep water tanks covered, and adopt precautionary measures such as using mosquito nets, repellents and protective clothing. The communiqué also directed mobilization of communities through mosques, schools and local notables to reinforce participation in preventive measures.

The CM emphasised that dengue prevention was a collective responsibility and that all the departments were accountable for ensuring public awareness as well as implementing effective on-ground interventions. He made it clear that the commissioners would be required to submit weekly reports on anti-dengue operations, hospital preparedness and awareness campaigns so that the drive against dengue could be pursued in a comprehensive and effective manner. — Bureau Report

PA passes bill to establish climate action board

Page 8

Demands release of Imran's detained nephews, action against those 'misusing powers'

By Mohammad Ashfaq

PESHAWAR: The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Assembly on Tuesday approved the KP Climate Action Board Bill, 2025, for the establishment of a climate action board.

The development came during a session chaired by Speaker Babar Saleem Swati.

The draft law moved by law minister Aftab Alam Afridi was unanimously passed by the house after the incorporation of amendments suggested by some opposition members.

Under the law, the climate action board will "plan, oversee and execute all climate-related initiatives, streamline decision-making and synergise cross-sector efforts to address climate risks faced by the province and for matters connected therewith and incidental thereto."

The draft bill says the climate action or climate initiatives mean any programmes, projects or activities meant to mitigate climate change and the

risks associated therewith, adapt to climate change, support climate change research and promote awareness about the climate change with the objective to reduce greenhouse gas emissions, encourage low-carbon economy, enhance climate change resilience and promote sustainable development.

Section 3 of the bill states that there will be the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Climate Action Board to coordinate and oversee climate strategies across departments to ensure harmonisation of efforts. The board will be administratively and functionally independent, while the government will make best efforts to promote, enhance and maintain the board's independence.

The board will have the authority to develop, review, amend and oversee the execution of climate policies and action plans for the province; advise government on climate policies, commitments and strategies; conduct and maintain provincial greenhouse gas inventories and establish emissions baselines, and conduct, promote and oversee research on mitigation, adaptation and climate finance.

The board will also be responsible for climate tagging of all schemes in the Annual Development Programme for alignment with climate goals,

mobilising financial resources for climate action and establish, operate and maintain the dedicated Climate Action Board Fund, and coordinating and pitching provincial projects for international climate financing like Green Climate Finance, Climate Investment Finance and Global Environment Facility.

It will also facilitate participation in carbon markets, support the generation of carbon credits, establish and implement carbon pricing mechanisms to encourage low-carbon development, monitor and evaluate the implementation and progress of climate action programmes and projects. Also, the board will conduct public awareness campaigns on climate change, promote environmental sustainability, engage with stakeholders, including communities, industries and civil society, and ensure community resilience to climate change, including systems for adoptive and shock responsive social protection.

The additional chief secretary (planning and development) will be the chairperson of the board, while its members include secretaries of the finance, law, climate change, energy and powers, transport, local government departments, four nominees from the private sector at least one woman and

two members of the provincial assembly to be nominated by the speaker.

Statement of object and reasons for the bill said KP faced growing climate-related threats, such as extreme weather, glacial melt and deforestation, which endangered lives, ecosystem and economic stability.

However, the absence of a centralised institutional mechanism has limited its ability to respond effectively.

The house also approved the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Aasan Karobar Bill, 2025, and the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Tourism (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

The lawmakers also adopted a resolution demanding the release of Shershah Khan and Shahraiz Khan, the nephews of PTI founder Imran Khan.

The resolution, moved by PTI MPA Asif Khan Mehsood, also called for the immediate withdrawal of "false and vindictive charges" against Shershah and Shahraiz.

It also demanded accountability of all those "misusing power" and urged authorities to ensure such acts are not repeated.

The resolution said no citizen should be subjected to arbitrary arrest, prolonged detention or political victimisation.

The chair later adjourned the session until next Friday.

Page 9 Flour millers blame Punjab ban for wheat crisis

By Aamir Shafaat Khan

KARACHI: As consumers continue to pay inflated prices for various flour types, millers have accused the Punjab government of creating an artificial wheat and flour crisis by imposing a ban under Section 144 on the inter-provincial movement of wheat and related products.

The Pakistan Flour Mills Association (PFMA) South Zone argued that such restrictions contradict the wheat deregulation policy and violate Article 151 of the Constitution, which allows the free movement of goods across provinces. The association warned that provincial-level curbs inevitably lead to nationwide disruptions.

PFMA South Zone Chairman Abdul Junaid Aziz, in a letter to Federal Minister for National Food Security and Research Rana Tanveer Hussain on Tuesday, said the ban had placed wheat stocks worth billions of rupees at risk in Punjab, especially in the wake of recent floods. The restriction also deprives consumers in other provinces of access to lower-priced flour.

He noted that Punjab accounts for 70pc of the country's wheat output, making other provinces heavily dependent on its surplus. "We are a single nation. Our joys and sorrows are shared. Such measures damage national unity," Aziz stated, calling on the federal government to intervene immediately.

He warned that the stored wheat in flood-affected areas could be destroyed if not moved promptly to safer locations in other provinces. "The Punjab government is taking a heavy risk by blocking the movement of wheat, endangering national food security and increasing financial losses to the exchequer," he said.

Aziz added that Punjab currently holds sufficient surplus wheat stocks and there is no justifiable reason for the movement ban.

Chaudhry Aamir Abdullah, Central Executive Member of PFMA South, proposed that the government either lift the inter-provincial movement restrictions or allow the private sector to import one million tonnes of wheat to avoid an imminent wheat and flour crisis.

He noted that the Punjab government had set up checkpoints at exit routes and motorway interchanges to monitor and block the transport of wheat and flour to other provinces. Millers warned that failure to act swiftly could lead to a severe flour shortage and further price hikes in the coming months.

SBP chief sees GDP expanding 3.25-4.25pc

Page 9

Textile Council urges EFS revival, cost cuts amid US tariffs on Indian exports

By Shahid Iqbal

KARACHI: The State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) has projected GDP growth between 3.25 and 4.25 per cent for FY26, based on improved macroeconomic indicators. However, the textile sector has warned that high production costs and policy constraints are undermining its global competitiveness, despite the improving

economic outlook.

Speaking at the annual meeting of the Pakistan Textile Council (PTC) on Tuesday, SBP Governor Jameel Ahmed highlighted key indicators supporting the growth forecast. These include a current account surplus in FY25, record remittances of \$38bn, and a rise in SBP's foreign exchange reserves to \$14.5bn — bolstered by \$7.8bn in purchases from the interbank market.

He noted that inflation had dropped to 3.2pc in June 2025, allowing the central bank to slash the policy rate from 22pc to 11pc over the year. Fiscal consolidation, reforms in exchange companies, and stable external debt

levels, he said, have contributed to market confidence and overall stability.

Despite the optimistic outlook, the textile sector expressed concern over its ability to remain competitive globally. Industry leaders questioned the growth forecast — particularly the upper bound of 4.25pc — citing extensive flood damage to key crops, especially cotton, which is vital to the sector. Cotton-producing areas in Sindh remain at risk as floodwaters continue to spread across the region.

PTC Chairman Fawad Anwar said the macroeconomic improvements are not translating into relief for exporters. He pointed

to the exclusion of essential raw materials from the Export Facilitation Scheme (EFS) and persistent structural barriers as key obstacles. “The global market is offering Pakistan a once-in-a-decade opportunity, especially after the US imposed a 50pc tariff on Indian textile exports, impacting \$16bn worth of shipments,” Anwar said.

“But unless bold policy action is taken now, Pakistan may miss this critical opening.” He urged the government to urgently restore EFS access, reduce the cost of doing business, and implement long-term measures to help the textile sector capture greater global market share.

Exports fall 12.5pc as demand dips in August

By Mubarak Zeb Khan

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan's merchandise exports slipped back into negative territory in August, fueling concerns among policymakers over weakening international demand and the country's eroding competitiveness in global markets.

This marks the fourth contraction in the last five months, with July offering only a brief respite through marginal growth. The persistent decline reflects mounting pressure on the country's trade performance as exporters face subdued external demand and a high cost of doing business.

According to data released by the Pakistan Bureau of Statistics (PBS) on Tuesday, exports fell by 12.49pc year-on-year to \$2.42 billion in August, down from \$2.76bn in the same month last year. On a month-on-month basis, export proceeds declined by 9.98pc.

During the first two months of the current fiscal year (July-August FY26), exports edged up by a marginal 0.65pc to \$5.11bn, compared to \$5.07bn in the same period of the previous year. The export growth of 16.91pc recorded in July was not enough to offset the broader trend of stagnation and decline.

The weakness in export performance was evident in previous months as well, with declines of 0.59pc in June, 10.07pc in May, and 7.36pc in April. Although March recorded a modest growth of 3.08pc, the trend reverted to negative in subsequent months.

In FY25, total exports stood at \$32.11bn, reflecting a 4.67pc increase from \$30.68bn in the previous fiscal year. However, the growth momentum weakened sharply after October, with several months registering negative or single-digit gains.

Despite the overall slump, global buyers have recently shifted apparel sourcing away from Bangladesh and China, opening up an opportunity for Pakistani exporters to capture market share. However, this potential remains underutilised due to structural challenges at home.

Trade deficit widens

Meanwhile, imports rose 6.42pc year-on-year to \$5.28bn in August, up from \$4.96bn in the same month last year. On a monthly basis, however, imports fell by 9.35pc.

In the first two months of FY26, the import bill increased by 14.23pc to \$11.2bn from \$9.73bn a year earlier. For the full FY25, imports rose 6.57pc to \$58.38bn, compared to \$54.78bn in the previous fiscal year.

As a result of declining exports and rising imports, the trade deficit widened significantly. In August, the deficit rose by 30.13pc to \$2.86bn, compared to \$2.21bn in the same month last year. Cumulatively, the deficit for July-August stood at \$6.02bn, up from \$4.66bn in the corresponding period last year.

For FY25, the annual trade deficit expanded by 9pc to \$26.27bn, from \$24.11bn a year earlier, raising concerns about the sustainability of external accounts in the face of fragile export growth and a rising import bill.

Senate panel warns IT ministry over telecom boards' secrecy

Page 9

Orders provision of required information in next meeting

By Kalbe Ali

ISLAMABAD: A parliamentary committee on Tuesday warned officials of the Ministry of Information Technology that a privilege motion could be moved against them after they refused to disclose the names of board members of state-owned telecom entities.

The warning was issued by Senator Palwasha Khan, chairperson of the Senate Standing Committee on IT and Telecom, after the special IT secretary declined to share the names of board members of PTCL and Ufone.

Committee members expressed annoyance as ministry officials continued to avoid the question for over half an hour despite repeated demands to disclose the names, perks, and criteria of selection of the board members.

The committee noted that the information had originally been sought on August 25. Officials maintained they still needed more time to collect the details. After

strong warnings, the committee directed the IT ministry to provide the required information in the next meeting.

Senators also raised the issue of PTCL's refusal to have its accounts audited by the Auditor General of Pakistan (AGP). The special secretary said PTCL was under private-sector management, but added that the ministry had no objection to an AGP audit.

5G spectrum auction

On another agenda item, the committee was informed that the prime minister has set December as the deadline for the 5G spectrum auction.

Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA) officials told the meeting that the consultant hired to finalise the auction policy had raised two major concerns. The first related to 140MHz spectrum in the 2,600MHz band, which remains stuck in litigation involving Southern Network Ltd (SNL).

Although there is no stay order, SNL has not released the spectrum. Committee members expressed concern that both the PTA and the IT ministry had previously failed to present the factual position. It was also noted that Zong is currently using over 6.6MHz spectrum and the matter is pending in court.

The second concern was the planned merger of Telenor Pakistan with PTCL. Senator Anusha Rehman said the ministry should engage with Telenor to reconsider its decision to exit Pakistan.

The committee also received a detailed briefing from the Frequency Allocation Board (FAB) on preparations for spectrum auctions. In addition, the National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA) briefed members on different forms of cyber fraud, warning that scams amounting to billions of rupees posed a serious threat to digital trust and financial inclusion.

The meeting also witnessed a heated exchange between PTA representatives and officials from the AGP over audit observations against Jazz. The AGP alleged that Jazz overcharged customers by Rs6.58 billion through quarterly tariff hikes of up to 15 per cent.

The committee directed both the PTA and the AGP to submit complete records and decided to continue reviewing the matter in the next session.

Senators Pervaiz Rashid, Dr Mohammad Humayun Mohmand, Dr Afnan Ullah, Saifullah Nyazee and Nadeem Ahmed Bhutto attended the meeting.

Urea sales surge ~~Page 9~~ in August

KARACHI: Urea sales rose sharply to 816,000 tonnes in August, up 46 per cent year-on-year and 34pc month-on-month, driven by aggressive discounting by select manufacturers and possible dealer pre-buying ahead of partial rollback in September.

Engro Fertilisers led the discount drive, offering an average price cut of Rs269 per bag during August — a portion of which was withdrawn at the start of September. The sales surge is also attributed to advance purchases by dealers taking advantage of the lower prices.

However, cumulative urea offtake during 8MFY25 declined by 10pc to 3.77 million tonnes compared to 4.21m tonnes in the same period last year, largely due to weaker farm economics.

According to Asad Ali of Topline Securities, urea closing inventory in August stood at 1.06m tonnes, down from 1.23m tonnes in July.—Staff Reporter

PTCL, Link Dot pay fines in ICH ruling

Page 9

ISLAMABAD: The Competition Commission of Pakistan (CCP) has recovered Rs495 million in partial penalties from Long Distance International (LDI) operators in the long-running International Clearing House (ICH) case, following the tribunal's endorsement of the CCP's original decision.

The recovery includes Rs458m from Pakistan Telecommunication Company Ltd (PTCL) and Rs37m from M/s Link Dot Net.

The Competition Appellate Tribunal recently upheld CCP's findings, which declared the ICH arrangement anti-competitive and unlawful. The ICH, introduced in 2012, routed all incoming international calls through a single PTCL-controlled gateway, eliminating market competition.

Under the ICH framework, call termination rates were fixed at 8.8 cents per minute — more than four times the previous rate — inflating costs for overseas callers while enabling operators to pocket revenue increases of over 300pc. The CCP had originally imposed penalties amounting to 7.5pc of each operator's annual turnover.

While the tribunal later reduced the fines to 2pc of revenues generated from the ICH arrangement, it ordered all operators to deposit the penalties within 30 days of the ruling.

CCP Chairman Dr Kabir Sidhu reiterated the Commission's commitment to enforcing competition law, warning businesses against collusion, price-fixing, and abuse of market dominance.— Staff Reporter

PSX defies flood concerns, hits new peak

By Muhammad Kashif

KARACHI: Shrugging off concerns over widespread flooding across Punjab and a looming super flood in Sindh, equity investors continued their buying spree on Tuesday, driving the Pakistan Stock Exchange (PSX) to a fresh all-time high. The benchmark KSE-100 index surged close to the 151,000-point barrier, extending its recovery for a third consecutive session.

The index rallied as much as 1,105 points during intraday trading before settling at 150,975 — up 1,004 points or 0.67pc. Key support came from Engro Holdings, Fauji Fertiliser, Engro Fertiliser, Bank Al-Habib, and Bank Alfalah, which collectively contributed 938 points to the gains, according to Topline Securities.

Ahsan Mehanti of Arif Habib Corporation attributed the bullish close to a

combination of upbeat economic indicators. These included a rise in foreign exchange reserves, lower consumer inflation at 3pc year-on-year, a 7pc year-on-year increase in oil sales for August, and anticipated

government spending on post-flood reconstruction. Ali Najib, Deputy Head of Trading at Arif Habib Ltd, said the market's northbound trajectory remained intact, with investor focus shifting towards the fertiliser sec-

tor. This was driven by expectations of a government-backed farmer relief package in the wake of crop damage from recent floods.

He added that stronger demand for urea and DAP, aimed at restoring soil fer-

tility, may help fertiliser manufacturers clear excess inventories built up in previous quarters.

On the macroeconomic front, Pakistan's trade deficit narrowed to \$2.86bn in August, down from \$3.1bn in July. This

development suggests reduced import pressure and relatively stable exports — a positive signal for external sector stability.

Despite the bullish sentiment, market activity weakened. Total trading volume declined by 8.62pc to 1.08bn shares, while traded value dropped 9.05pc to Rs44.24bn. The Bank of Punjab once again dominated the volume charts for a third straight day, with 174.3 million shares traded — highlighting robust investor participation as the market eyes another record-breaking session.

Analysts said the 150,000 mark has now emerged as a strong support level, underpinned by narrowing trade deficits and growing optimism over relief measures for the agriculture sector.

With momentum building and liquidity remaining healthy, the PSX appears poised to scale fresh highs in the coming sessions.

PAKISTAN STOCK EXCHANGE

T H E T O P F I V E R S				ACTIVITY	
GAINERS		LOSERS		LEADERS*	
Unilever Foods	283.80	PIA Holding CoB	642.50	The Bank of Punjab	174.38
Siemens Pakistan	133.37	Hoechst Pakistan	237.28	Pak Elektron	52.71
Indus Motor	52.61	Nestle Pakistan	56.46	First National Equities	39.77
Sitara Chemical	45.84	Sazgar Engg	41.18	K-Electric	31.65
Service Industries	37.54	Sapphire Textile	28.07	Waves Corporation	30.83
(Share values in rupees)				* Volume in millions of traded shares	
I N D I C A T O R S				PARTICIPANTS	
	Tuesday	Previous	Change	Foreign	▼ \$0.86m
KSE 100-SHARE INDEX (Points)	150,975.48	149,971.12	▲ 1,004.36	Companies	▼ \$0.14m
KSE 30-SHARE INDEX (Points)	45,968.76	45,655.03	▲ 313.73	Banks	▼ \$1.34m
MARKET CAPITAL (Rs billion)	17,855.530	17,800.728	▲ 54.802	Mutual Funds	▲ \$2.72m
TRADING VALUE (Rs billion)	44.424	48.849	▼ 4.425	Individuals	▲ \$3.10m

Construction activity spurs cement demand

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Total despatches rose 21pc in July-August FY25

By Our Staff Reporter

KARACHI: Rising construction activity continued to fuel cement demand in August, with total sales climbing 10.33pc year-on-year to 3.097 million tonnes, up from 2.807m tonnes in the same month last year. Export volumes also posted a strong gain, rising 22.13pc to 749,723 tonnes from 613,857 tonnes in August 2024.

According to data released by the All Pakistan Cement Manufacturers Association (APCMA), overall cement despatches — including domestic sales and exports — reached 3.846m tonnes in August 2025, up 12.45pc from 3.421m tonnes in the same month last year.

The previous month, July 2025, showed even stronger performance, with domestic sales up 18.61pc and exports surging 84pc year-on-year.

During the first two months of FY25 (July–August), total cement despatches

rose by 21pc to 7.847m tonnes compared to 6.492m tonnes in the same period of FY24. Domestic consumption stood at 6.090m tonnes, up 14.25pc from 5.331m tonnes, while exports surged 51.29pc to 1.757m tonnes from 1.161m tonnes.

An APCMA spokesperson noted that despite challenges posed by heavy rains and flooding in parts of the country, the sector has shown resilience. He urged the government to reduce taxes on cement to ease reconstruction costs in flood-affected areas.

Fahad Hussain Khan of BMA Capital Management estimated cement capacity utilisation in August 2025 at 56pc, compared to 51pc in August 2024 and 59pc in July 2025.

According to the Pakistan Bureau of Statistics (PBS), cement prices varied regionally during the month. In the North, the average retail price rose by Rs19 per 50kg bag month-on-month (MoM) to Rs1,396, while in the South, it fell by Rs5 per bag to Rs1,443.

Mr Khan added that cement demand is likely to recover further in FY26, supported by improved fiscal space, easing inflation, and lower interest rates.

Paperboard industry warns of dumping risk

Page 9

Seeks import price revision to avert job, factory losses

By Khalid Hasnain

LAHORE: The government's decision to fix a low Import Trade Price (ITP) of \$610 per tonne for coated bleached board is likely to encourage the dumping of cheaper paperboard products — primarily from China — posing a serious threat to Pakistan's domestic industry. Millers warn of job losses, revenue erosion, and idle capacity as they struggle to compete with underpriced imports.

The Pakistan paperboard industry has criticised the ITP as significantly lower than India's recently imposed minimum import price (MIP) of \$770 per tonne (CIF) for the same product, reflecting New Delhi's efforts to protect its local industry. The \$160 per tonne gap — a 26pc difference — has created an unlevel playing field, local producers say.

"While India is shielding its capacity, employment, and investment, Pakistan is becoming a dumping ground for Chinese surplus," said an industry source. "Our mills are rapidly losing market share and profita-

bility."

The coated bleached board — also known as folding box board — is widely used in packaging across the pharmaceutical, FMCG, food, and export sectors. Domestic manufacturers, who have invested heavily in machinery and co-generation plants, claim to have sufficient capacity to meet 100pc of national demand, replacing the need for imports.

The industry argues that undervaluation of imported paperboard has led to a surge in under-invoiced shipments, which not only harms local production but also deprives the government of legitimate customs revenue. It has urged authorities to revise the ITP in line with the Indian benchmark to restore competitiveness and curb dumping.

In 2018, the National Tariff Commission (NTC) imposed a 28pc anti-dumping duty on the product, but it was never enforced. Exporters subsequently altered product descriptions to bypass the duty, prompting a fresh NTC investigation, which industry sources claim is facing procedural delays. As a result, monthly imports — previously 5,000–5,500 tonnes — have more than doubled, averaging 12,000 tonnes during the last fiscal year, further squeezing local manufacturers.



(FROM left) Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping and Ukhnaagiin Khurelsukh, the presidents of Russia, China, and Mongolia, respectively, pose for a photo during a meeting in Beijing.—AFP

Xi hosts ‘old friend’ Putin, Kim in challenge to West

Russia signs up new gas pipeline to boost supplies to China

BEIJING: China’s President Xi Jinping convened his Russian and North Korean counterparts in Beijing for the first time on Tuesday, a show of solidarity with countries shunned by the West over their role in Europe’s worst war in 80 years.

Xi hosted Vladimir Putin for talks at the Great Hall of the People and then at his personal residence, calling him his “old friend”. A few hours later, Kim Jong Un’s armoured train was spotted by a witness arriving in the Chinese capital. North Korean state media confirmed Kim’s arrival, showing his daughter Kim Ju Ae accompanying him.

Ju Ae, whom South Korean intelligence consider her father’s most likely successor, is making her international debut after years of being seen next to Kim at major domestic events. Xi, Putin and Kim are set to take centre stage at a massive military parade on Wednesday, where the Chinese president will flaunt his vision for a new global order as US President Don-

ald Trump’s “America First” policies strain Western alliances.

Beyond the pomp, analysts are watching whether the trio may signal closer defence relations following a pact signed by Russia and North Korea in June 2024, and a similar alliance between Beijing and Pyongyang, an outcome that may alter the military calculus in the Asia-Pacific region. It would also be a blow for Trump, who has talked up his close relations with all three leaders and touted his peacemaking credentials as Russia’s three-and-a-half-year war with Ukraine has raged on.

In a thinly veiled swipe at this rival across the Pacific Ocean on Monday, Xi told a summit of more than 20 leaders of non-Western countries: “We must continue to take a clear stand against hegemonism and power politics.” Xi also held talks on Monday with Prime Minister Narendra Modi of India, whose country has been targeted by Trump over its purchases of Russian oil seen as helping finance Putin’s war effort.

Trump’s Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent called the summit “performative” and accused China and India, the biggest buyers of Russian crude, of being “bad actors” by fuelling Russia’s war.

As Putin and Xi met, Russia’s

Gazprom and China National Petroleum Corporation signed a deal to increase gas supplies and penned an agreement on a new pipeline that could supply China for 30 years.

Alarm bells

At a time when Trump has set his sights on a Nobel Peace Prize, any new concentration of military power in the East that includes Russia will ring alarm bells for the West.

“Trilateral military exercises between Russia, China and North Korea seem nearly inevitable,” wrote Youngjun Kim, an analyst at the US-based National Bureau of Asian Research, in March, citing how the conflict in Ukraine had pushed Moscow and Pyongyang closer. “Until a few years ago, China and Russia were important partners in imposing international sanctions on North Korea for its nuclear and missile tests... (they) are now potential military partners of the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea during a crisis on the Korean peninsula,” he added, using the diplomatically isolated country’s official name.

The North Korean leader has supplied more than 15,000 troops to support Putin’s war in Ukraine.—Reuters

Germany ready to consider case of Afghans deported by Pakistan

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BERLIN: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz said on Tuesday his government was considering an urgent appeal for help from more than 200 Afghans who have been deported back to their Taliban-run homeland from Pakistan.

The group are among roughly 2,400 Afghans who have fled their country for Pakistan in recent years after being told Germany would grant them refuge — before Berlin's approach to migrants hardened under a new government.

The group of over 200, whom Pakistan deported in mid-August, called their anonymous letter, "a desperate plea for urgent intervention to save our lives" from the threat of Taliban retaliation.

Merz, asked about the letter during a Berlin press conference, said he took it "seriously" and pledged that legally binding commitments given by previous German governments would be honoured.

After the Taliban returned to power in 2021, Berlin set up a scheme to offer sanctuary to Afghans who had worked with German forces in Afghanistan or who were deemed at particular risk from the Taliban, for example journalists, lawyers and human rights activists. Since Merz's conservative-led coalition government took power in May, it has put the process on ice as part of a wider push to toughen immigration policy.

'Constant threat' from Taliban

As alarm has grown about many of those now left in limbo, Berlin on Monday allowed a first group of 47 Afghans who had successfully taken legal action to fly to Germany.

The group of over 200

who were deported to Afghanistan — among them rights activists, artists, former judges and their families — wrote of their desperate plight in a letter sent Monday to the chancellery and the foreign and interior ministries.

"Trusting in the commitments of the Federal Republic of Germany and hoping to begin a safe life in Germany, we left Afghanistan despite grave threats and perilous journeys," they wrote.

They said they had travelled to Islamabad expecting to receive German visas within months but, in many cases, had been waiting for more than three years.

Since being deported to Afghanistan last month, they had been "living in constant fear inside a so-called 'safe shelter' organised by your partners".

"The constant threat of Taliban entry, the fear of revenge, arbitrary detention, abduction, torture or death has created unbearable psychological trauma," they added.

Merz said the government was now reviewing the eligibility of Afghans to enter Germany "on a case-by-case basis".

"There are some cases that are very clear. There are other cases that are not so clear. And in any case, a security check is required before each individual entry."

He added that "Germany has entered into a number of legal obligations under the previous government, which it must of course also fulfil under this government".

"All cases are subject to review, particularly with regard to security," he said. "And with this in mind, we are of course also considering the request of the 200 Afghans who have approached us."

—AFP

Israel can't stop Palestinian state's recognition, Macron says

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US urged to revise decision on visas

PARIS: French President Emmanuel Macron said on Tuesday Israel cannot stop a push towards the recognition of a Palestinian state through its expanded offensive in Gaza or by annexing more Palestinian territory.

France is one of several countries planning to recognise the state of Palestine at the upcoming UN General Assembly in New York, with Belgium becoming the latest Western nation to announce it would follow suit.

"No offensive, annexation attempt, or forced displacement of populations will derail the momentum" towards the two-

state solution, Macron said on X after speaking with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman.

The French head of state also lambasted the US decision to deny visas to members of the Palestinian Authority to attend the meeting in New York as "unacceptable", a decision also criticised by Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan.

"We call for this measure to be reversed and for Palestinian representation to be ensured in accordance with the Host Country Agreement," Macron added.

His intervention comes as Israel steps up operations in Gaza, despite mounting pressure over the devastating humanitarian consequences for the coastal territory's besieged civilian population.—AFP

Over the moon: fake astronaut scams

Japanese octogenarian

Page 10

TOKYO: A Japanese octogenarian was swindled out of thousands of dollars after falling in love online with a self-described astronaut who sought her help to avert a spaceship crisis, police said on Tuesday.

The hapless woman in Japan's northern Hokkaido island met the fraudster in July on social media. He claimed to be a male astronaut, police said, describing the case as a "romance scam".

After some exchanges, the scammer one day told her he was "in space on a spaceship right now", but was "under attack and in need of oxygen", police said.

The scammer then urged her to pay him online to help him buy oxygen, and successfully hoodwinked around one million yen (\$6,700) out of her.

The woman lives alone and started developing feelings for him as their online communication progressed, local media said, quoting investigative sources.

"If a person you met on social media ever demanded cash from you, please be suspicious of the possibility of scam, and report to police," a police official said.

Japan has the world's second-oldest population after tiny Monaco, according to the World Bank, and older people frequently fall prey to various forms of organised fraud. These include the classic "it's me" scam, where perpetrators impersonate family members in trouble to extract money from the victim.—AFP

Trump hints at sending troops to 'most dangerous city' Chicago

Page 10

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump vowed on Tuesday to quickly and dramatically reduce crime in Chicago, hinting at sending federal troops into what he branded the "most dangerous city in the world".

"I will solve the crime problem fast, just like I did in DC," Trump posted on his Truth Social platform, referring to his deployment of National Guard reservists to the US capital beginning last month.

"Chicago is the worst and most dangerous city in the World, by far," he said, adding that JB Pritzker, the Democratic governor of the state of Illinois where Chicago is located, "needs help badly, he just doesn't

know it yet." Trump cited what he described as the latest crime statistics from America's third-largest city: Some 54 people shot in Chicago over the holiday weekend, including eight deaths, with similar figures for the previous two weekends. "Chicago will be safe again, and soon," he said.

Trump followed up with a provocative, all-caps post: "CHICAGO IS THE MURDER CAPITAL OF THE WORLD!" The abrasive comments come as the Republican leader repeatedly threatens to send thousands of US military personnel into Democratic strongholds like Chicago and Baltimore, cities he has slammed as high-crime zones flooded with undocumented immigrants.

Pritzker has clashed with Trump in recent days, accusing the president of launching "an invasion" with the deployments as he seeks to boost his anti-crime, anti-immigration agenda.

Thousands of National Guard troops and US Marines were deployed to Los Angeles beginning in June, intended to assist police as they cracked down on protests and unrest over Trump's sweeps for undocumented migrants.

Trump also ordered the deployment of the National Guard into Washington in August, and has claimed the move improved city safety. He has said such a deployment could dramatically reduce crime in Chicago,

home to some 2.7 million people and one of the country's most diverse cities.

President as police chief?

The unprecedented steps are being challenged in federal court. On Tuesday a federal judge declared that Trump effectively violated the law when he used troops in Los Angeles, and barred the Pentagon from ordering National Guard reservists or Marines to perform police functions including arrests, security patrols or searches and seizures. Judge Charles Breyer of the District Court in San Francisco warned in his ruling that Trump appears intent on "creating a national police force with the

President as its chief." Breyer's injunction, however, would only come into force on September 12, potentially leaving an opening for the conservative-majority US Supreme Court to rule on the case.

As Chicago residents braced for a possible intervention by Trump — reportedly as early as this week — its Democratic mayor delivered a spirited defense of the Windy City. "No federal troops in the city of Chicago! No militarized force in the city of Chicago!" Mayor Brandon Johnson said Monday at a rousing Labor Day rally.

"We're going to take this fight across America, but we've got to defend the home front first," he added.—AFP



SOLDIERS carry three skulls during a ceremony in Antananarivo to celebrate their return to Madagascar from France.—AFP

Madagascar receives skull of king beheaded by France

ANTANANARIVO: Madagascar marked at a ceremony on Tuesday the return from France of the skulls of three men killed by French troops 128 years ago, including one believed to be that of a decapitated king.

France handed over the skulls in Paris on Aug 27, in the first such restitution since it passed a law in 2023 facilitating the return of human remains seized during its colonial conquests.

They are believed to belong to King Toera of the Sakalava people, who was beheaded by French troops in 1897, and two of his warriors.

The remains arrived in Madagascar on Monday and were received at the airport by members of the Sakalava group dressed in traditional robes.

Held in three boxes draped with the flag of the Indian Ocean nation, they

were driven through the capital Antananarivo to the city's mausoleum on Tuesday, where they were welcomed by President Andry Rajoelina and a gathering of government and Sakalava dignitaries. "If we want to move forward, we must know our past, our history," Rajoelina told the gathering.

"We are proud to have had a king and his soldiers who protected the nation," he said, praising a people who rose against French colonial troops "with courage and daring".

King Toera's great-grandson, the newly enthroned Sakalava king Georges Harea Kamamy, sprinkled water from the sacred Tsiribihina River to welcome home his ancestor's remains. "We Sakalava are relieved. Today is a day of joy," Kamamy said. —AFP



AFRAA Al-Noaimi attends the red carpet for *L'Etranger* (The Stranger) at the festival.—AFP

Gaza mother hopes Page 11 film about slain child will help end war

GAZA CITY: The mother of Hind Rajab, a five-year-old Palestinian girl killed by Israeli forces in Gaza, hopes that a film about her final moments, to be screened on Wednesday at the Venice Film Festival, would help end the war.

Rajab's body was recovered from a car riddled with bullets in Gaza City days after she was last heard from, in a desperate, hours-long phone call to the Palestinian Red Crescent on Jan 29, 2024.

She had made the emergency call after her family's car came under fire during an attempt to flee Gaza City amid an Israeli advance in the Palestinian territory's north. Her death sparked international outrage and calls for an independent investigation, and the original audio recordings of her emergency call has been incorporated into *The Voice of Hind Rajab*, one of 21 features competing at the Venice festival.

"I hope this film will help stop this destructive war and save the other children of Gaza," her mother Wissam Hamada said by phone from Gaza City in a call ahead of the premiere in the Italian city.

"My daughter Hind's voice has become heard all over the world and she will never be forgotten," the 29-year-old mother said. To Hamada, who lost her husband a year ago, their slain daughter "is just one case among thousands". Her death has grabbed international attention, but "why didn't the world act to save other parents and children?" said the mother, who now lives with her five-year-old son.

"The whole world has left us to die, to go hungry, to live in fear and to be forcibly displaced without doing anything. It's a huge betrayal." *The Voice of Hind Rajab*, by Tunisian director Kaouthar Ben Hania, recounts the last hours of the girl's life using the original recordings, with the family's permission according to Hamada.

Rajab's body was eventually recovered along with six relatives and two Red Crescent rescue workers sent to find her.—AFP

Bigelow spotlights nuclear threat in comeback film at Venice

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VENICE: US director Kathryn Bigelow launched her latest movie *A House of Dynamite* at the Venice Film Festival on Tuesday, saying she hoped the tense thriller would sound the alarm over the ever-present danger of nuclear catastrophe.

Her first film in eight years traces the launch of a lone, unidentified ballistic missile towards the United States, triggering a desperate race to find out who is responsible and how to respond.

"This is a global issue, like where we are with nuclear weapons," said Bigelow, who in 2010 became the first woman to receive the best director Oscar for her Iraq war movie *The Hurt Locker*.

"Of course, hope against hope, maybe we reduce the nuclear stockpile someday, but in the meantime we are really living in a house of dynamite," she told a press conference, alongside some of her stars, including Idris Elba and Rebecca Ferguson.

"How is annihilating the world a good defensive measure?" The film tracks the 18 minutes it takes for the missile to be launched from the Pacific



(FROM LEFT) US director Kathryn Bigelow, Swedish actress Rebecca Ferguson and actress Greta Lee attend the red carpet of the movie, *A House of Dynamite*, at the International Venice Film Festival.—AFP

until it reaches Chicago, unfolding through the eyes of myriad officials—from the US president to an anti-missile crew based in Alaska to military brass working inside US Strategic Command.

"(There are) these incredibly competent people operating on an infinitesimally short timeline, and the fate of the world is at stake," Bigelow said.

Bigelow's last major movie was the 2017 historical crime

drama *Detroit*. Before that, she dramatised the decade-long hunt for Osama bin Laden in *Zero Dark Thirty*.

With *A House of Dynamite*, Bigelow revisits the sweeping, politically resonant storytelling that defined her most celebrated work.

Mutually assured destruction

Defence analysts believe there are up to 13,000 nuclear weapons in the world, in the

hands of nine countries—more than enough warheads to destroy life on earth many times over.

"We've constructed this weaponry that could end all life, and it's miraculous, frankly, that something horrific hasn't happened already. So many of these weapons are on a hair trigger system in countries like ours," said the scriptwriter Noah Oppenheim, a former president of NBC News.

Cast members said portraying characters caught inside a nuclear crisis was harrowing.

"I learned I don't have the courage to be in politics," said Elba, who plays the US president. Jared Harris, who plays the US defence secretary echoed that sentiment.

"I am grateful that I will never be put in that situation," he said.

A House of Dynamite is one of three films US streamer Netflix is showcasing at Venice. The other two are Guillermo del Toro's *Frankenstein* and Noah Baumbach's *Jay Kelly*.

All three are competing for the prestigious Golden Lion prize, which will be awarded on Sept 6.—Reuters

Denmark high court rules Dane in IS was spy, not fighter

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COPENHAGEN: Denmark's Supreme Court ruled on Tuesday that a Dane of Syrian origin who was jailed for having spent time with the militant Islamic State group in Syria was in fact an informant for Danish intelligence services.

The case has captivated the Nordic country for years and has shone an embarrassing spotlight on its intelligence agencies.

The ruling paves the way for Ahmed Samsam, 35, to seek a reversal of his 2018 conviction in Spain for being a member of the group.

"The Danish Security and Intelligence

Service (DSIS) and the Danish Defence Intelligence Service (DDIS) must acknowledge that, in connection with his trips to Syria in 2013 and 2014, 'A' collaborated with intelligence services, and that he received fees and other compensations in exchange for providing information on Danish fighters in Syria to the intelligence services," the court said in its verdict.

The two agencies published a public admission within hours of the court ruling.

Since Samsam's case emerged in 2018, both intelligence services had refused to confirm or deny the identity of their inform-

ers for security reasons. A lawyer for the intelligence agencies called Tuesday's ruling "regrettable".

Samsam was handed an eight-year sentence by the Madrid court that convicted him. He served most of his time in prison in Denmark after being transferred, and was released in 2023. He had denied any terrorist activity, and his claim had been backed by several testimonies and journalistic investigations, which were presented to a lower Danish court that tried to establish whether or not he was a Danish intelligence agent. He lost that case, before the Supreme

Court ruled in his favour.

It found that he had explained "in detail, in a coherent and meaningful manner" how he had been recruited, and that he had documented cash and bank transfer payments, the identity of his recruiters, his training and meeting places.

"Our main goal is to pursue the matter in Spain. We need to think carefully about the best steps to take to do so," Samsam's lawyer Rene Offersen told reporters outside the courthouse.

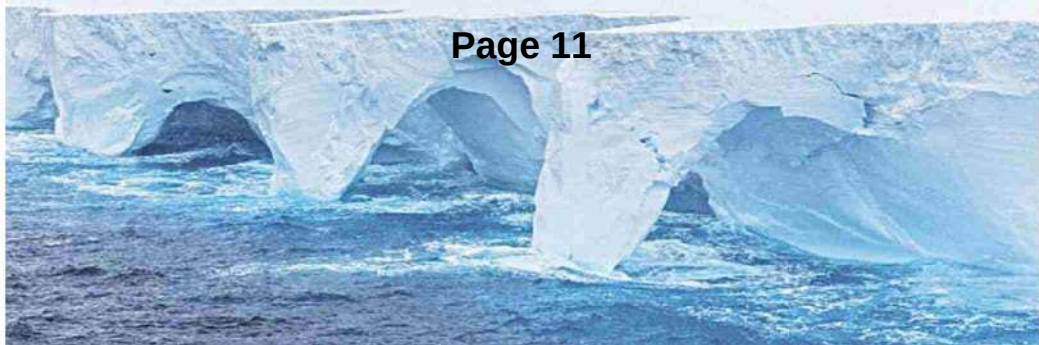
The case has enthralled Danes for five years. "I have a lot of confidence in the

Danish courts, but I never thought it would take this long," Samsam told reporters as he left the courthouse.

"Especially not after the media started covering the story in 2020," he added.

The affair has left the intelligence agencies red-faced. Samsam said that could have been avoided if the agencies had backed him up in 2018. "I don't know which monkeys have been running the show over there but they really made a big mistake and they have handled it like amateurs," he said.

"The fact that they let it get so public, they can only blame themselves."—AFP



AN aerial view of the A23a iceberg in the Southern Ocean, off Antarctica.—AFP/file

Once king of the seas, a giant iceberg is finally breaking up

PARIS: Nearly 40 years after breaking off Antarctica, a colossal iceberg ranked among the oldest and largest ever recorded is finally crumbling apart in warmer waters, and could disappear within weeks.

Earlier this year, the “megaberg” known as A23a weighed a little under a trillion tonnes and was more than twice the size of Greater London, a behemoth unrivalled at the time.

The gigantic slab of frozen freshwater was so large it even briefly threatened penguin feeding grounds on a remote island in the South Atlantic Ocean, but ended up moving on.

It is now less than half its original size, but still a hefty 1,770 square kilometres (683 square miles) and 60 kilometres (37 miles) at its widest point, according to analysis of satellite images by the EU earth observation monitor Copernicus.

In recent weeks, enormous chunks — some 400 square kilometres in their own right — have broken off while smaller chips, many still large enough to threaten ships, litter the sea around it.

It was “breaking up fairly dramatically” as it drifted further north, Andrew Meijers, a physical oceanographer from the British Antarctic Survey, said. “I’d say it’s

very much on its way out... it’s basically rotting underneath.

The water is way too warm for it to maintain. It’s constantly melting,” he said. “I expect that to continue in the coming weeks, and expect it won’t be really identifiable within a few weeks.”

A23a calved from the Antarctic shelf in 1986 but quickly grounded in the Weddell Sea, remaining stuck on the ocean floor for over 30 years. It finally escaped in 2020 and, like other giants before it, was carried along “iceberg alley” into the South Atlantic Ocean by the powerful Antarctic Circumpolar Current.

Around March, it ran

aground in shallow waters off distant South Georgia island, raising fears it could disrupt large colonies of adult penguins and seals there from feeding their young. But it dislodged in late May, and moved on.

Swinging around the island and tracking north, in recent weeks the iceberg has picked up speed, sometimes travelling up to 20 kilometres in a single day, satellite images analysed showed.

Exposed to increasingly warmer waters, and buffeted by huge waves, A23a has rapidly disintegrated. Scientists were “surprised” how long the iceberg had kept together, said Meijers.—AFP

Judge bars Trump from using troops in California

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LOS ANGELES: A US judge on Tuesday blocked the Trump administration from using the military to fight crime in California, as the Republican president threatens to send troops to more cities, including Chicago.

San Francisco-based judge Charles Breyer found that the Trump administration violated a law, known as the Posse Comitatus Act, with its June deployment of 4,000 National Guard and 700 active duty Marines to Los Angeles. The law sharply limits the use of federal troops for domestic enforcement.

The decision dealt a setback to Trump's push to expand the role of the military on US soil, which critics say is a dangerous expansion of executive authority that could spark tensions between troops and ordinary citizens.

Breyer put the ruling on hold until Sept 12. The Trump administration is likely to appeal. White House spokeswoman Anna Kelly called Breyer a "rogue judge" and said the military deployment had saved Los Angeles from "mass chaos".

"The president is committed to protecting law-abiding citizens, and this will not be the final say on the issue," Kelly said in an emailed statement. The injunction applies only to the military in California, not nationally.

But the judge said that Trump's stated desire to send troops to Chicago and other cities provided support for his ruling, noting that the president said at an Aug 27 cabinet meeting that he had the right to "do anything I want to do ... if I

think our country is in danger".

Trump has said the troops were needed in Los Angeles to protect federal agents carrying out immigration enforcement, after large-scale raids triggered protests.

"There is no question that federal personnel should be able to perform their jobs without fearing for their safety," wrote Breyer, who was nominated to the bench by President Bill Clinton, a Democrat, and is the brother of Stephen Breyer, a former Supreme Court judge.

"But to use this as a hook to send military troops alongside federal agents wherever they go proves too much and would frustrate the very purpose of the Posse Comitatus Act."

The Los Angeles deployment drew wide condemnation from Democrats, who said Trump was using the military to stifle opposition to his hardline immigration policies.

"The people of California won much-needed accountability against Trump's ILLEGAL militarisation of an American city!" California Governor Gavin Newsom, a prominent Democrat who brought the lawsuit, wrote on X.

Trump has since deployed the National Guard to Washington, a federal district where Trump wields exceptional power, and said he may send troops to Chicago, the nation's third-largest city.

The Republican president has cited crime rates to justify the need for federal troops. Washington and Chicago, like many places across the US, experienced crime spikes in the wake of the pandemic, but

crime is on a declining trend in both cities.

'Unprecedented shift'

At a three-day trial last month, lawyers from the California attorney general's office tried to show that the troops had performed police functions, including setting up security perimeters and detaining two people, and were not needed in the first place.

They warned that a ruling for the Trump administration would "usher in a vast and unprecedented shift in the role of the military in our society."

The Trump administration countered that the constitution permits presidents to use troops to protect federal personnel and property as an exception to the Posse Comitatus Act.

The administration's lawyers tried to show that the troops only acted to protect federal agents from perceived threats and stayed within their legal limits.

The administration still had several hundred soldiers in Los Angeles when the trial took place, although the protests had long died down.

The troops were used for security during raids on marijuana farms outside the city and as a show of force to deter protests at a popular park during an operation by immigration agents, according to evidence shown at trial. About 300 National Guard troops remain deployed to Los Angeles, and the Trump administration has said they would stay there at least until November.—Reuters

Landslide flattens Sudan village, killing over 1,000

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African Union appeals to both parties in the civil war to allow aid to enter affected areas

KHARTOUM: Rescue teams were struggling to reach a remote mountain village in Sudan's Darfur region on Tuesday after a devastating landslide buried almost the entire community killing more than 1,000 people.

Heavy rain triggered the disaster on Sunday, flattening the village of Tarasin in the Jebel Marra range, the rebel Sudan Liberation Movement/Army (SLM) faction which controls the area said in a statement, adding that there was only one survivor.

"Initial information indicates the death of all village residents, estimated at more than 1,000 individuals, with only one survivor," the faction led by Abdulwahid al-Nur said, calling the landslide "massive and devastating".

The group appealed to the United Nations and other aid organisations for help recovering the dead still buried under mud and debris. "This is beyond our capacity," Nur said via a messaging app.

"Masses of mud fell onto the vil-

lage. Our humanitarian teams and local residents are trying to retrieve the bodies, but the scale of the disaster is far greater than the resources available to us," he said.

Buried beneath the mud

The African Union urged Sudan to "silence the guns" and allow aid delivery to victims of the deadly landslide.

"In these painful circumstances, the chairperson of the Commission... calls on all Sudanese stakeholders to silence the guns and unite in facilitating the swift and effective delivery of emergency humanitarian assistance to those in need," the bloc said in a statement.

Images the SLM published on its website appeared to show huge sections of the mountainside collapsed, burying the village under thick mud and uprooted trees.

Footage showed people standing on jagged rocks as they searched for those buried beneath the mud.

The SLM controls parts of the Jebel Marra range and has mostly stayed out of the conflict, but hundreds of thousands of people have fled into SLM-held territory to escape the violence.

Jebel Marra is a rugged volcanic range stretching about 160 kilometres southwest of North Darfur's besieged state capital El-Fasher,

which the RSF is pushing to capture after besieging it for more than a year.

The area is prone to landslides, particularly during the rainy season which peaks in August. A 2018 landslide in nearby Toukoli killed at least 20 people.

'Painful disaster'

Since April 2023, Sudan has been ravaged by a war that erupted from a power struggle between army chief Abdel Fattah al-Burhan and his former deputy, RSF commander Mohamed Hamdan Daglo. The rivals have responded to Sunday's disaster.

Burhan's Transitional Sovereignty Council, which heads the internationally recognised government based in Port Sudan on the Red Sea coast, mourned the victims on Tuesday.

It pledged to mobilise all available resources to support those affected by what it described as a "painful disaster".

The rival government based in South Darfur state capital Nyala also weighed in on the tragedy.

Mohamed Hassan al-Taayshi, prime minister in the RSF-backed government, expressed deep sorrow and said solidarity must rise above politics.

"This is a profoundly human mom-



PEOPLE inspect the debris after a landslide devastated the village of Tarasin, in Sudan's Jebel Marra area.—AFP

ent," he said, adding that "the lives and safety of Sudanese citizens are above any political or military considerations".

He also said that he had spoken directly with SLM leader Nur to assess needs on the ground.

Much of Darfur — including the area where the landslide occurred — remains inaccessible to international aid organisations due to ongoing fighting, severely limiting the delivery of emergency relief.

The disaster also comes during Sudan's rainy season, which often

renders mountain roads impassable. In Sudan's main war zones like Darfur, infrastructure was already fragile after more than two years of fighting.

Burhan's forces retook central Sudan in a series of offensives earlier this year, leaving the RSF in control of most of Darfur and parts of Kordofan in the south. The paramilitaries have moved to set up a rival government in the territories they still control.

This week, RSF commander Daglo was sworn in as head of its

newly-formed presidential council while Taayshi was sworn in as prime minister. The war has killed tens of thousands of people and driven more than 14 million from their homes, according to UN figures.

UN response

The United Nations said Tuesday it is working to respond to a devastating landslide in Sudan's Darfur region that buried an entire mountain village, killing as many as 1,000 people.

"The United Nations and our humanitarian partners are mobilising to provide support to the affected population," UN humanitarian coordinator in Sudan Luca Renda said in a statement. Citing sources on the ground, Renda said the death toll from the landslide was believed to be between 300 and 1,000.

"Our humanitarian teams and local residents are trying to retrieve the bodies, but the scale of the disaster is far greater than the resources available to us," he said.

Pope saddened

In a telegram published by the Vatican, Pope Leo XIV said he was "deeply saddened to learn of the devastation caused by the landslide", praising the civil authorities and emergency personnel.—AFP

Israel amasses troops ahead of offensive in Gaza City

• Forces kill 56 Palestinians, including 10 in air strike on residential building • Belgium to recognise Palestinian state at UNGA

JERUSALEM: Israel intensified its military build-up on Tuesday as reservists began responding to call-up orders ahead of a planned offensive to capture Gaza City, nearly two years into a devastating war.

Despite mounting pressure at home and abroad to end its campaign in the Palestinian territory, Israel is gearing up to seize Gaza's largest city — intensifying bombardments and operating in the outskirts in recent days.

Gaza's civil defence agency said Israeli forces killed at least 56 people on Tuesday, including 10 in an air strike on a residential building in the southwest of Gaza City.

AFP footage from the aftermath of the strike in the Tel al-Hawa neighbourhood showed Palestinians carrying a dead girl from the rubble of the top floor.

"We were sleeping safely in our homes and suddenly we woke up to the sound of bombing and destruction and found most of our neighbours murdered and injured," said Sanaa al-Dreimli.

The United Nations estimates that nearly a million people live in Gaza City and its surroundings, where a famine has been declared.

In a statement, the Israeli military said it had been preparing in recent days "ahead of expanded combat operations and the large-scale mobilisation of reservists".

Speaking at an event in Jerusalem, Defence Minister Israel Katz said: "Tens of thousands of reservists have left their homes, families and jobs to once again

answer the national call — the return of all prisoners and the neutralisation of Hamas."

Approving the military's plans for the conquest of Gaza City in late August, Katz said he had authorised the call-up of about 60,000 reservists.

Israeli media reported that some 40,000 reservists were being called up in the first mobilisation wave.

On the ground in Gaza City, weary Palestinians told AFP they felt helpless and desperate ahead of the looming offensive.

"There is no place for us to go, and no means to get there. We are exhausted physically and mentally from displacement and from the war," 60-year-old Amal Abdel-Aal, who lives in a tent in western Gaza City, told AFP by telephone.

"We have come to wish for death."

Palestinian state

Belgium on Tuesday became the latest Western country to say it will recognise the State of Palestine at the UN General Assembly this month, following similar announcements by Australia, Canada and France.

"Palestine will be recognised by Belgium at the UN session! And firm sanctions are being imposed against the Israeli government," Foreign Minister Maxime Prevot wrote on X.

In July, French President Emmanuel Macron said France would recognise a Palestinian state at the UN meeting, due to be held from September 9 to 23 in New York. More than a dozen other Western countries have since

called on others to do the same.

Prevot said the decision came "in view of the humanitarian tragedy" unfolding in Gaza, where Israeli offensives have displaced most of the population at least once and the UN has declared a famine.

"In the face of the violence perpetrated by Israel in violation of international law, given its international obligations, including the duty to prevent any risk of genocide, Belgium had to take strong decisions to increase pressure on the Israeli government and Hamas terrorists," Prevot wrote.

"This is not about punishing the Israeli people, but rather about ensuring that its government respects international and humanitarian law and taking action to try to change the situation on the ground," he added.

In a post on X on Tuesday, the military's Arabic-language spokesman warned Gazans of the upcoming "expansion of combat operations towards Gaza City".

"We wish to remind you that in Al-Mawasi enhanced services will be provided, with an emphasis on access to medical care, water and food," Avichay Adraee said, referring to an area in the south which Israel designated a humanitarian zone in the early months of the war but which has been hit by repeated strikes.

In mid-August, UN human rights office spokesman Thameen al-Kheetan said Palestinians in Al-Mawasi had "little or no access to essential services and supplies, including food, water, electricity and tents".—AFP



LIVESTOCK shelter inside a damaged house following a deadly magnitude-6.0 earthquake that struck Mazar Dara, in Afghanistan's Kunar province.—Reuters

Aftershocks rock Afghanistan as death toll tops 1,400

- Rescuers comb through rubble in Kunar after over 5,400 homes destroyed
- Families endure wet weather with minimal shelter

MAZAR DARA: Strong aftershocks to a powerful earthquake that killed more than 1,400 people at the weekend rattled eastern Afghanistan on Tuesday as survivors in remote hard-hit villages prepared for another night without shelter.

Temporary shelters had not yet reached the Mazar Dara area of Kunar province, with roads still blocked to the remote, mountainous region bordering Pakistan where the worst of the earthquake was felt.

"There is no food... there is nothing, everything has been buried in the rubble," Nurgal district official Ijazul Haq Yaad told *AFP*.

Residents, including elderly people and children were "in the open air" with little to protect them from wet weather, he said, adding that "we still feel strong aftershocks".

A 5.2-magnitude earthquake jolted the region near the epicentre of the magnitude 6.0 earthquake that hit late Sunday night — one of at least six aftershocks recorded by the US Geological Survey.

"These aftershocks are constant, but they have not caused any casualties yet," Ehsanullah Ehsan, the disaster management spokesman in Kunar, told *AFP*.

The number of victims from Sunday's

earthquake has mounted steadily, with 1,411 people dead and 3,124 injured in Kunar alone, chief Taliban government spokesman Zabihullah Mujahid said on Tuesday, making it one of the deadliest to hit the country in decades.

Another dozen people were killed and hundreds injured in neighbouring Nangarhar province.

Afghanistan is one of the poorest countries in the world, with dwindling aid since the Taliban seized power in 2021, undermining its ability to respond to disasters. The devastation could affect "hundreds of thousands", said United Nations humanitarian coordinator for Afghanistan Indrika Ratwatte.

Rescuers searched through the night and all day for survivors in the rubble of homes flattened in Kunar, where more than 5,400 houses were destroyed, government spokesman Hamdullah Fitrat said.

The European Union said it was sending 130 tonnes of emergency supplies and providing one million euros (\$1.2m) to help victims of the deadly quake.

The bloc has become one of the key aid donors to Afghanistan after the United States — previously the country's largest aid provider — cut all but a slice of its assistance after President Donald Trump took office in January.

The aid cuts risk impeding the response to the earthquake, sector experts told *AFP*, in a country already facing one of the world's worst humanitarian crises after decades of conflict.

"The scale of need far exceeds current resources," the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC) said, noting that funding cuts had hit humanitarian air services, "limiting access to remote communities".

IFRC said it had launched an emergency appeal for 25m Swiss francs (\$31m) to help with the earthquake response and recovery, as various countries pledged to send support.

As Taliban military helicopters flew in food and continued to transport victims, residents buried their dead, including children, wrapping them in white shrouds and praying over their bodies before laying them to rest.

Sunday's earthquake epicentre was about 27 kilometres (17 miles) from Jalalabad, according to the USGS, and just eight kilometres below the Earth's surface.

Many of those living in the quake-hit villages were among the more than four million Afghans forced back to the country from Iran and Pakistan in recent years.—*AFP*

Villagers marooned after deadly floods in Indian Punjab

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Over 1,000 boats, 30 helicopters deployed to rescue the stranded, supply food

AMRITSAR: A thousand villages in India's Punjab state are marooned by deadly floods, with thousands forced to seek shelter in relief camps, government authorities say.

Flooding across the north-western state killed at least 29 people and affected over 250,000 last month, with the state's chief minister calling it "one of the worst flood disasters in decades".

The region is often dubbed India's breadbasket, but more than 940 square kilometres (360 square miles) of farmland are flooded, leading to "devastating crop losses", Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann wrote in a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

PM Modi on Monday assured him of the federal government's "full support".

Authorities have said they fear a "huge loss of livestock", the full extent of which will only be clear when the waters recede, according to a bulletin issued by the state authorities late Monday.

India's army and disaster



PEOPLE stand outside their flooded houses in New Delhi after a rise in the water level of Yamuna River due to heavy rains.—Reuters

teams have carried out vast rescue operations, deploying more than 1,000 boats and 30 helicopters to rescue the stranded or supply food. "The most important thing is to save the lives of people and helpless animals trapped in the water," Mann said in a statement.

Rivers in the region cross into Pakistan, where floodwater has also engulfed swathes of land.

Floods and landslides are common during the June-September monsoon season in the subcontinent, but experts say climate change, coupled with poorly planned develop-

ment, is increasing their frequency, severity and impact.

Northwest India has seen rainfall surge by more than a third on average from June to September, according to the national weather department.

In the capital Delhi, relentless rains have swollen the Yamuna river — which breached its danger mark on Tuesday, inundating several areas and creating traffic snarl-ups lasting for hours.

Deadly floods triggered by record-breaking rain also killed dozens in India-held Kashmir last month.—AFP

90pc of world lives on degraded land, unhealthy air, water stress: WB

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By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: Ninety per cent of the world lives with either degraded land, unhealthy air, or water stress, according to a new World Bank report, which says that restoring natural systems is possible and can yield high returns.

In low-income countries alone, eight of out ten people live without all three — healthy air, water, and land — according to the report, 'Reboot Development: The Economics of a Livable Planet'. New evidence shows that the loss of forests disrupts rainfall, dries soils, and worsens droughts, costing billions of dollars.

The report also identifies a nitrogen paradox where fertilisers boost yields, but overuse in some regions harms crops and ecosystems, costing as much as \$3.4 trillion annually. And air and water pollution silently damage health, productivity, and cognition, thereby sapping human potential, the report estimates.

If managed well, however, nature can create jobs, drive economic growth, and build resilience. Using natural resources more efficiently could reduce pollution by as much as 50 per cent. Improving farm-level practices of nitrogen fertiliser use can deliver 25 times

greater benefits than their cost, while boosting crop yields.

Improving water and sanitation services could be lifesaving: chlorinating water at point of use could save a quarter of the children that prematurely die from water-related issues. "Pollution markets" not only reduce air pollution, they are also cost effective: each dollar spent yields about \$26 to \$215 in benefits.

Around 80 pc of the people in low-income countries live with all three environmental stressors — degraded land, polluted air, and water stress. By contrast, in high-income countries 43 per cent of people are not exposed to any of the three stressors.

The report says the scale of impacts is so vast that humans have transitioned from being passive beneficiaries of the planet to becoming the dominant force in its transformation.

Today humans and their livestock account for an astonishing 95 per cent of total mammalian biomass (by weight) on Earth, leaving wild mammals a vanishing 5 per cent.

The Earth has transgressed six of the nine environmental thresholds — termed "Planetary Boundaries" — needed for human progress, the report says.

US demands for Page 12 missiles block N-talks: Iran

DUBAI: Iran said on Tuesday the path to nuclear negotiations between Iran and the United States is not closed but US demands for curbs on Iranian ballistic and hypersonic missiles are obstructing prospects for talks.

A sixth round of Iran-US talks was suspended after Israel and the US struck Iranian military and nuclear facilities and Iran retaliated with waves of ballistic and hypersonic missiles against Israel.

“We indeed pursue rational negotiations. By raising issues such as missile restrictions, they set a path that negates any talks,” the secretary of Iran’s Supreme National Security Council, Ali Larijani, said in a post on X.

Western countries claim Iran’s uranium enrichment programme could yield material for an atomic warhead and that it seeks to develop a ballistic missile to carry one.

Iran says its nuclear programme is only for electricity generation and other civilian uses and that it is enriching uranium as fuel for these purposes.

It has denied seeking to create missiles capable of carrying nuclear payloads and says its defence capabilities cannot be open to negotiation in any talks over its atomic programme.

Larijani’s comments follow last week’s launch by France, Germany and Britain of a “snapback mechanism” that could re-impose UN sanctions on Tehran over its nuclear programme.

The three countries have urged Iran to engage in nuclear negotiations with the US, among other conditions, in order to have the imposition of the snapback sanctions delayed for six months.—Reuters

WHO warns of global mental health crisis

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- Data shows over 1bn people worldwide live with mental health disorders; anxiety and depression are the second leading cause of long-term disability
- Suicide causes one in every 100 deaths; mental health disorders cost the world economy an estimated \$1tr annually

By Ikram Junaidi

ISLAMABAD: More than one billion people suffer from mental health disorders, with suicide claiming over one in every 100 lives and leaving families worldwide to cope with its devastating impact, the WHO has warned.

Speaking to reporters, Devora Kestel, the interim head of the WHO's non-communicable disease and mental health department said, "Globally, suicide accounts for more than one in every 100 deaths, and for each death, there are 20 suicide attempts."

She added that those suicides "affected countless more lives and livelihoods, as friends, carers and loved ones were forced to grapple with unimaginable hardship."

Conditions such as anxiety and depression are taking an immense human and economic toll. While many countries have bolstered their mental health policies and programmes,

greater investment and action are needed globally to expand services to protect and promote people's mental well-being.

Mental health conditions such as anxiety and depression are highly prevalent in all countries and communities, affecting people of every age and income level. They are the second leading cause of long-term disability, contributing significantly to the loss of healthy life. They drive up health-care costs for affected people and families, while inflicting substantial economic losses on a global scale.

Meanwhile, the new findings published in two reports — World Mental Health Today and Mental Health Atlas 2024 — highlight some areas of progress while exposing significant gaps in addressing mental health conditions worldwide.

These reports serve as critical tools to inform national strategies and shape global dialogue ahead of the 2025 United Nations High-Level

Meeting on noncommunicable diseases and the promotion of mental health and well-being, scheduled for September 25 in New York.

"Transforming mental health services is one of the most pressing public health challenges," said Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, WHO Director-General. "Investing in mental health means investing in people, communities, and economies — an investment no country can afford to neglect."

Every government and every leader has a responsibility to act with urgency and to ensure that mental healthcare is treated not as a privilege, but as a basic right for all."

Key data

The reports show that while prevalence of mental health disorders can vary by sex, women are disproportionately impacted overall. Anxiety and depression are the most common types of mental health disorders

among both men and women.

Suicide remains a devastating outcome, claiming an estimated 727,000 lives in 2021 alone. It is a leading cause of death among young people in all countries and across socioeconomic groups.

Despite global efforts, progress in reducing suicide mortality is too low to achieve the United Nations Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) target of a one-third reduction in suicide rates by 2030. On the current trajectory, only a 12 per cent reduction will be achieved by that deadline.

The economic impact of mental health disorders is staggering. While healthcare costs are high, the indirect costs — particularly from lost productivity — are even greater. Depression and anxiety alone cost the global economy an estimated \$1 trillion each year.

The reports reveal a concerning stagnation in mental health investment. Median government spending

on mental health remains at just 2pc of total health budgets — unchanged since 2017. Disparities between countries are stark; while high-income countries spend up to \$65 per person on mental health, low-income countries spend as little as \$0.04. The global median number of mental health workers is only 13 per 100,000 people, with extreme shortages in low- and middle-income countries.

Reform and development of mental health services are progressing slowly. Fewer than 10pc of countries have fully transitioned to community-based care models, with most still in the early stages of transition.

Encouragingly, most countries report having functional mental health promotion initiatives such as early childhood development, school-based mental health programmes and suicide prevention strategies.

Over 80pc of countries now offer mental health and psychosocial support as part of emergency responses.